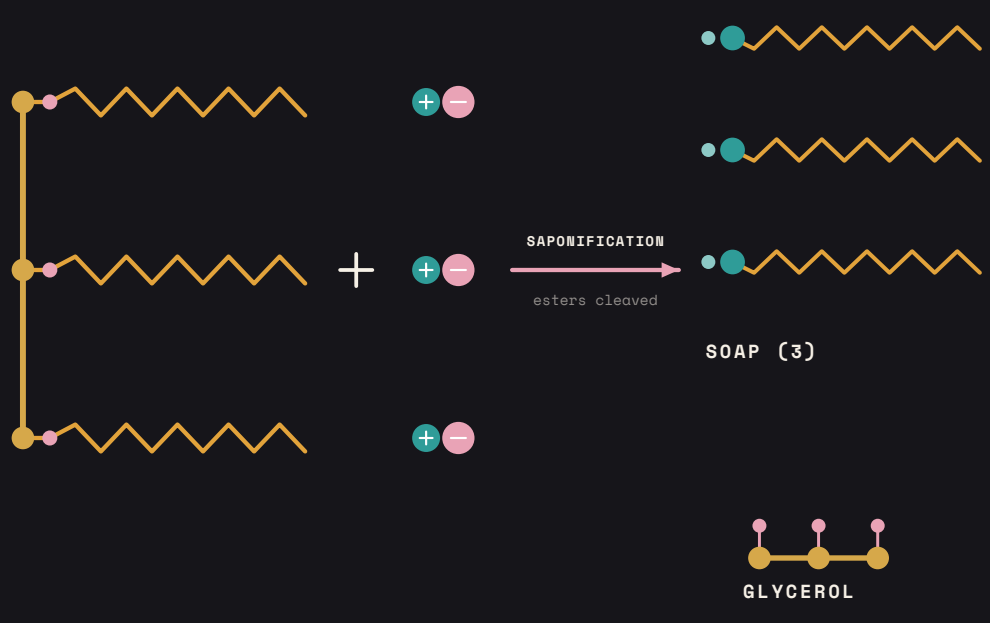
SAPONIFICATION



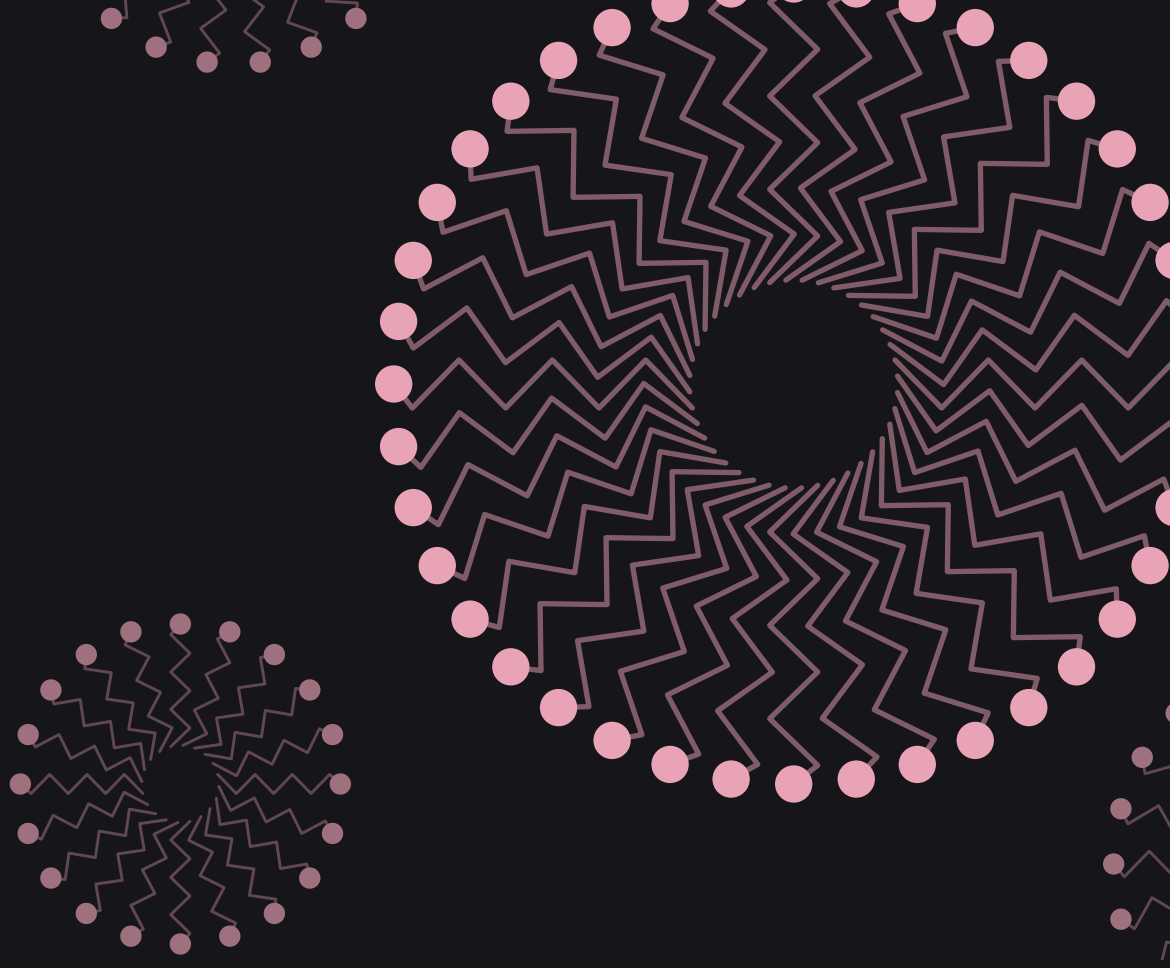


FAT
triglyceride

LYE
3 NaOH

FAT + LYE → SOAP + GLYCEROL

THE REACTION ON WHICH THIS BOOK IS BUILT



SAPONIFICATION

Thymos, Expenditure, and the Rendering of the Subject in *Fight Club*

A Dialectical Chemistry of Late-Capitalist Selfhood, with Comparative Studies in Myth, Speculative Fiction, and the Philosophy of the Double

A DISSERTATION

FAT + LYE ⟶ SOAP + GLYCEROL

Saponification: Thymos, Expenditure, and the Rendering of the Subject in *Fight Club*

Source text: *Fight Club (Restored v9)*.
Trim 7 × 10 in. Set in Crimson Text, DM Serif Display, Bebas Neue and Space Mono.
Figures and chapter openers drawn for this edition.

“Society everywhere is in conspiracy against the manhood of every one of its members.”

RALPH WALDO EMERSON, “SELF-RELIANCE” (1841)

“Man brennt Etwas ein, damit es im Gedächtniss bleibt: nur was nicht aufhört, weh zu thun, bleibt im Gedächtniss.”

FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE, ZUR GENEALOGIE DER MORAL (1887)

ABSTRACT

This dissertation argues that *Fight Club*, Chuck Palahniuk's novel (1996) and David Fincher's film from Jim Uhls's screenplay (1999), read here as a single composite text, is neither the anti-consumerist satire its defenders describe nor the fascist fantasy its prosecutors indict, but an allegory of *saponification*: the alkaline hydrolysis in which a fat, cleaved by a caustic agent, yields two inseparable products, soap and glycerol. The text literalizes the reaction at the level of plot, since Tyler Durden renders liposuctioned human fat into luxury soap and, from its glycerol by-product, explosive. The dissertation demonstrates that the same chemistry organizes the text's philosophy. The narrator's catalogued identity is the fat: inert, accumulated surplus, Bataille's accursed share congealed into furniture. Tyler is the lye: the caustic negativity of pain, death-awareness, and inscription that Hegel called *Verweilen beim Negativen* and that Nietzsche identified as the mnemotechnic by which memory, debt, and conscience are burned into the human animal. The products are the space monkey (hard, uniform, nameless, interchangeable: the self rendered into the commodity of its own purification) and Project Mayhem (the volatile residue whose destiny is detonation). Because the reaction cannot yield one product without the other, the text's notorious ideological bivalence is not a failure of interpretation but a stoichiometric fact.

Three concepts are introduced. *Autothymia* names the condition of a self-consciousness which, deprived at the Kojèvian end of history of any Other capable of granting recognition, manufactures an internal antagonist through dissociation; it recasts the Hegelian struggle for recognition as an autoimmune process whose terminal act is the narrator's self-wounding. *Amargi*, after the Sumerian term for debt-release that literally means "return to the mother," designates the regressive-utopian horizon of the text's assault on the archive of debt, binding together Nietzsche's "second innocence," the Levitical Jubilee, and the narrator's recurrent flight toward maternal holding. *The unsaponifiable* names the fraction of a fat that resists alkaline cleavage; in *Fight Club* it is Marla Singer, the text's one irreducible Other, whose refusal of both purification and explosion furnishes the narrative's only exit from the reaction.

The argument proceeds through a genealogy of the text's philosophical sources (Hegel, Kojève, Fukuyama, Nietzsche, Kierkegaard, Bataille, Mauss, Freud, Lacan, Girard, Heidegger, Jünger, Marx, Lukács, Debord, Baudrillard, Derrida, the Cynics, Zen, Emerson, and Thoreau) and through comparative readings across myth (the Promethean division of fat at Mecone, Gilgamesh and Enkidu, Iron Hans, the *Bacchae*, Jacob at the Jabbok, Odysseus as Nobody, the *Hymn of the Pearl*, Ragnarök) and across philosophical and speculative fiction (Hogg, Poe, Stevenson, Dostoevsky, Conrad, Kafka, Huxley, Zamyatin, Burgess, Dick, Ballard, Kesey, Ellis, DeLillo, Pynchon, Borges, and the American cinema of 1999). It concludes that the text's ethical wager is

located neither in the soap nor in the explosion but in the emulsion of its final shot, two hands held against collapsing towers, which the dissertation reads as a metastable colloid rather than a dialectical synthesis. From this reading it derives a general method, *saponific criticism*, for the analysis of late-capitalist narratives of conversion, radicalization, and self-overcoming.

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NOTE ON TEXTS AND CONVENTIONS

Fight Club without qualification designates the composite text constituted by Palahniuk's novel (New York: W. W. Norton, 1996) and the Twentieth Century Fox film directed by David Fincher from Jim Uhls's screenplay (1999). Where the versions diverge, most consequentially in the first meeting of narrator and Tyler (a nude beach in the novel, an aircraft in the film), in the targets of Project Mayhem (a national museum in the novel, the headquarters of credit-card companies in the film), and in the dénouement (a failed detonation and an asylum the narrator mistakes for Heaven in the novel, a completed demolition watched hand in hand with Marla in the film), the divergence is treated not as noise but as evidence, since the variants arrest the same reaction at different stages.

The novel itself began as a seven-page short story in the anthology *Pursuit of Happiness* (1995); expanded to novel length, it became the sixth chapter, the one in which the narrator recites fight club's rules.

The protagonist is called "the narrator." The name "Jack," which the screenplay gives him and the film uses only in its parody of the *Reader's Digest* series in which bodily organs narrate their own lives (the novel's "Joe"), is reserved for discussion of the text's economy of names. Philosophical and literary works are cited by date of original publication or composition; translations from German, French, Greek, and Russian are the present writer's unless otherwise indicated. Quotation from the primary text is held to the minimum the analysis requires, and dialogue is paraphrased wherever paraphrase does not compromise the argument. Chemical terms carry their standard meanings; where they function as concepts they are italicized at first use and formalized in Chapter Seven. No technical procedure for any hazardous process is described or implied: the text's notorious recipes, which both novel and film are reported to have corrupted deliberately, are discussed solely as figures.



00

INTRODUCTION

The Rendering Plant

STAGE 00 / THE RENDERING PLANT

0.1 An Object That Will Not Settle

Few texts of the late twentieth century have proved so resistant to stable interpretation, or so hospitable to contradictory appropriation, as *Fight Club*. Released in the United States on 15 October 1999, after a premiere at the Venice Film Festival on 10 September and a marketing campaign that never found a register for it, the film was received as a provocation in search of a doctrine. Roger Ebert, giving it two stars, pronounced it "frankly and cheerfully fascist," and David Denby called it "a fascist rhapsody posing as a metaphor of liberation"; sympathetic reviewers read the same images as a Swiftian exposure of the masculinity they appeared to celebrate. The academic reception reproduced the split at higher resolution. Henry Giroux's influential indictment (2001) found in the film a pedagogy of masculine violence that mistook a critique of consumption for a critique of capital and the restoration of patriarchal authority for emancipation, and with Imre Szeman he extended the charge to an "IKEA boy" whose revolt never exceeds the horizon of a more authentic male dominance. Against this prosecution a psychoanalytic counter-tradition, from Slavoj Žižek's reading of the self-beating scene (2002) to Krister Friday's Lacanian account of a narrator who seeks recognition from History itself (2003), read the violence as the symptom the film diagnoses rather than the cure it prescribes. Fincher himself called it a coming-of-age film, a *Graduate* for people in their thirties; on that account its protagonist must reject a fantasy of masculine completion in order to grow up.

Neither party anticipated what followed. The text's afterlife has been a demonstration, conducted at civilizational scale, of its refusal to settle. The novel's sneer at the "beautiful and unique snowflake" migrated into the political vernacular of the American right as an epithet for its opponents. Its iconography was adopted by online subcultures of aggrieved masculinity that took Tyler Durden as an exemplar rather than a symptom. Its debt-erasing climax prefigured the jubilee politics of the post-2008 left, from Occupy Wall Street to Strike Debt's Rolling Jubilee, and was restaged with acknowledged indebtedness in Sam Esmail's *Mr. Robot* (2015–19). In January 2022 the Chinese platform Tencent Video replaced the film's final sequence with an intertitle announcing that, thanks to clues provided by Tyler, the police had uncovered the whole plan and arrested every criminal. Palahniuk first mocked the change as a happy ending for everyone and then observed that it had brought the film almost exactly into line with his novel, whose bombs fail and whose narrator wakes in an asylum; after international ridicule the platform restored eleven of the twelve minutes it had cut, all but a sex scene. A text that can be claimed by the manosphere and by Occupy, censored into fidelity to its own source, and read by equally competent critics as fascist and as anti-fascist is not merely ambiguous. Its ambiguity has a structure, and that structure is the object of this dissertation.

> *Its ambiguity has a structure, and that structure is the object of this dissertation.*

0.2 Method: Material Imagination and Dialectical Chemistry

The thesis advanced here takes the text's most literal image as its most rigorous concept. The soap that Tyler manufactures from human fat stolen from a liposuction clinic's medical waste, and sells to department stores at twenty dollars a bar, is ordinarily read as an emblem: of consumer recycling, of the rich sold back their own excess, of the commodity's obscene origin. This dissertation proposes that it is not an emblem but a process, and that the chemical reaction by which soap is made supplies a more exact model of the text's philosophical movement than any of the dialectical, psychoanalytic, or sociological schemata criticism has imposed upon it.

The proposal has distinguished precedent. Hegel's *Science of Logic* (1812–16) assigns to *chemism* a determinate place in the logic of objectivity, between mechanism and teleology: the moment at which differentiated objects stand in tension toward one another and are neutralized into a product in which their difference is extinguished. Goethe's *Elective Affinities* (1809) built a novel of adultery on the chemistry of double decomposition, in which the pairs AB and CD recombine as AD and BC. Gaston Bachelard's psychoanalyses of fire, water, and earth (1938–48) showed that substances carry a *material imagination* that organizes reverie and theory alike. Roland Barthes's "Saponides et détergents" (1957) read the advertising of cleansers as a mythology of depth and purification, opposing the caustic fluid, imagined as a liquid fire that kills dirt, to the powder that merely separates dirt from its object. Anne McClintock's *Imperial Leather* (1995) exposed soap as the commodity through which Victorian imperialism advertised its civilizing mission, and Primo Levi's *The Periodic Table* (1975) made chemistry the grammar of a life. What these precedents share is a refusal to treat the chemical figure as ornament. The present study extends that refusal to its limit, on the premise that a text which stages the manufacture of soap from human bodies has already proposed its own hermeneutic.

0.3 The Reaction Stated

Saponification is the alkaline hydrolysis of a triglyceride. A fat, consisting of three fatty-acid chains joined by ester bonds to a glycerol backbone, is treated with a strong base: in the hard soaps of modern commerce, sodium hydroxide, the "lye" with which Tyler also burns the narrator's hand. The ester bonds are cleaved. The chains, now carboxylate salts, become soap; the backbone, liberated, becomes glycerol, the "sweet principle" of fats that Carl Wilhelm

Scheele isolated in 1779 and that, once nitrated, became the explosive foundation of Alfred Nobel's fortune.

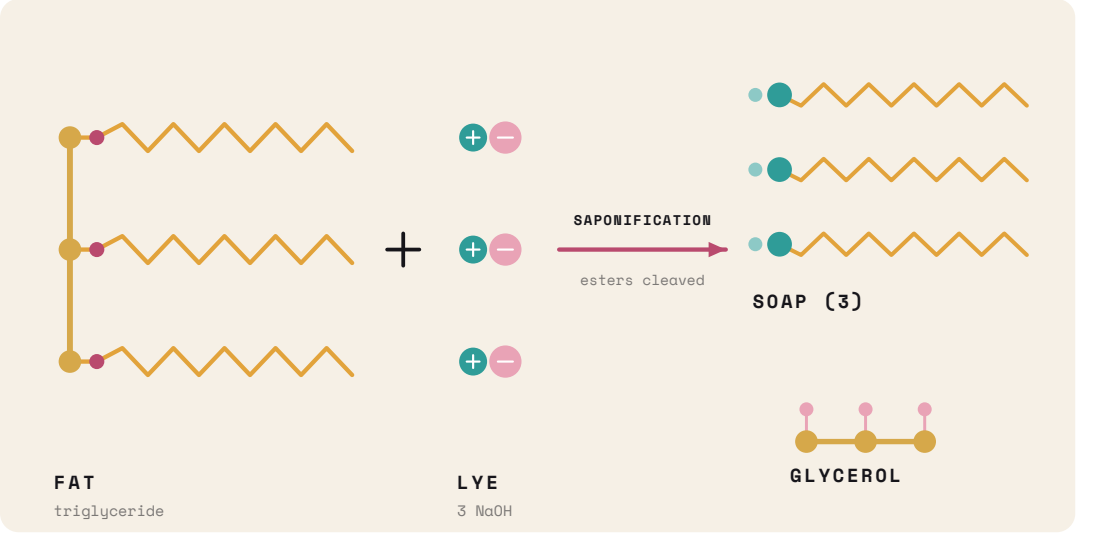


FIG. 1 THE REACTION

Saponification: a fat, three fatty-acid chains on a glycerol backbone, is cleaved by lye into three molecules of soap and one of glycerol. Each term names a moment of the text.

Four further facts of the chemistry bear the weight of the argument. The soap molecule is *amphiphilic*: one end hydrophilic, the other lipophilic, a single molecule with a divided nature. Above a *critical micelle concentration*, amphiphiles in water assemble spontaneously into *micelles*, spheres whose lipophilic tails hide within while their hydrophilic heads face the surrounding medium; at higher concentrations they order themselves into liquid-crystalline *mesophases*. A soap's cleansing power depends on its capacity to stabilize an *emulsion*, a metastable suspension of immiscible liquids. And every natural fat contains an *unsaponifiable fraction* (sterols, pigments, hydrocarbons) that the base cannot cleave and that survives the reaction unchanged.

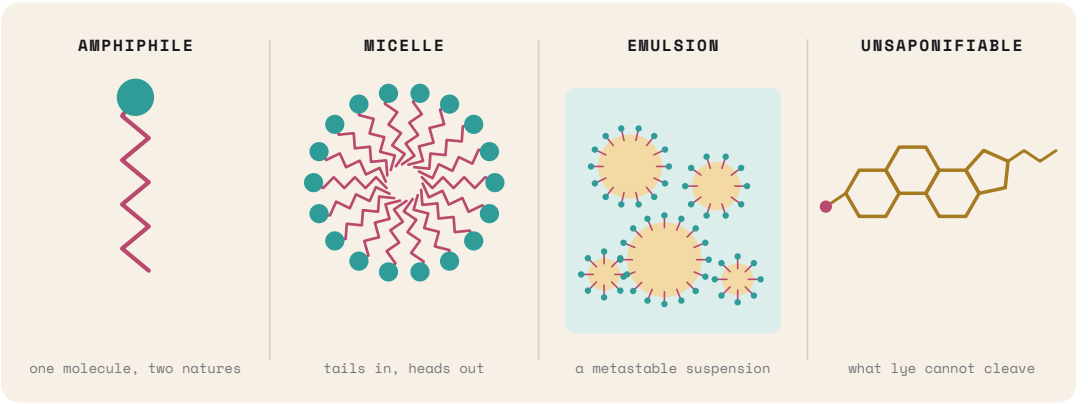


FIG. 2 FOUR FURTHER FACTS

The amphiphile, the micelle, the emulsion and the unsaponifiable fraction: the properties of soap on which the argument rests.

Each term, the following chapters argue, names a determinate moment of *Fight Club*. The narrator's catalogued identity is the fat; Tyler is the lye; fight club, governed by a rule of silence that turns a violent core inward and a compliant surface outward, is the micelle; its proliferation past a threshold of density is the phase transition that yields Project Mayhem's ordered mesophase; the space monkey is the soap; the bombs are the glycerol; the narrator–Tyler compound is the amphiphile; Marla Singer is the unsaponifiable fraction; and the final image of two hands held against falling towers is an emulsion. The model is heuristic rather than reductive. Its claim is that the text's philosophy has the *form* of this reaction, and that the form explains what content-based readings cannot: above all, why every critique the text mounts arrives accompanied by the violence it critiques.

0.4 Three Concepts

The model generates three concepts offered as the dissertation's principal contributions. *Autothymia*, from *thymos*, the spirited part of the soul that Plato's *Republic* places between appetite and reason and that Alexandre Kojève and Francis Fukuyama made the motor of history, designates the condition of a self-consciousness that, unable to find among the "single-serving" others of consumer society any Other capable of granting recognition, splits in order to produce one. Autothymia is the Hegelian struggle for recognition conducted after the end of history and inside a single skull. Its dynamics of escalation, collectivization, and autoimmune self-destruction trace the trajectory from the parking-lot fight to the gun in the narrator's mouth.

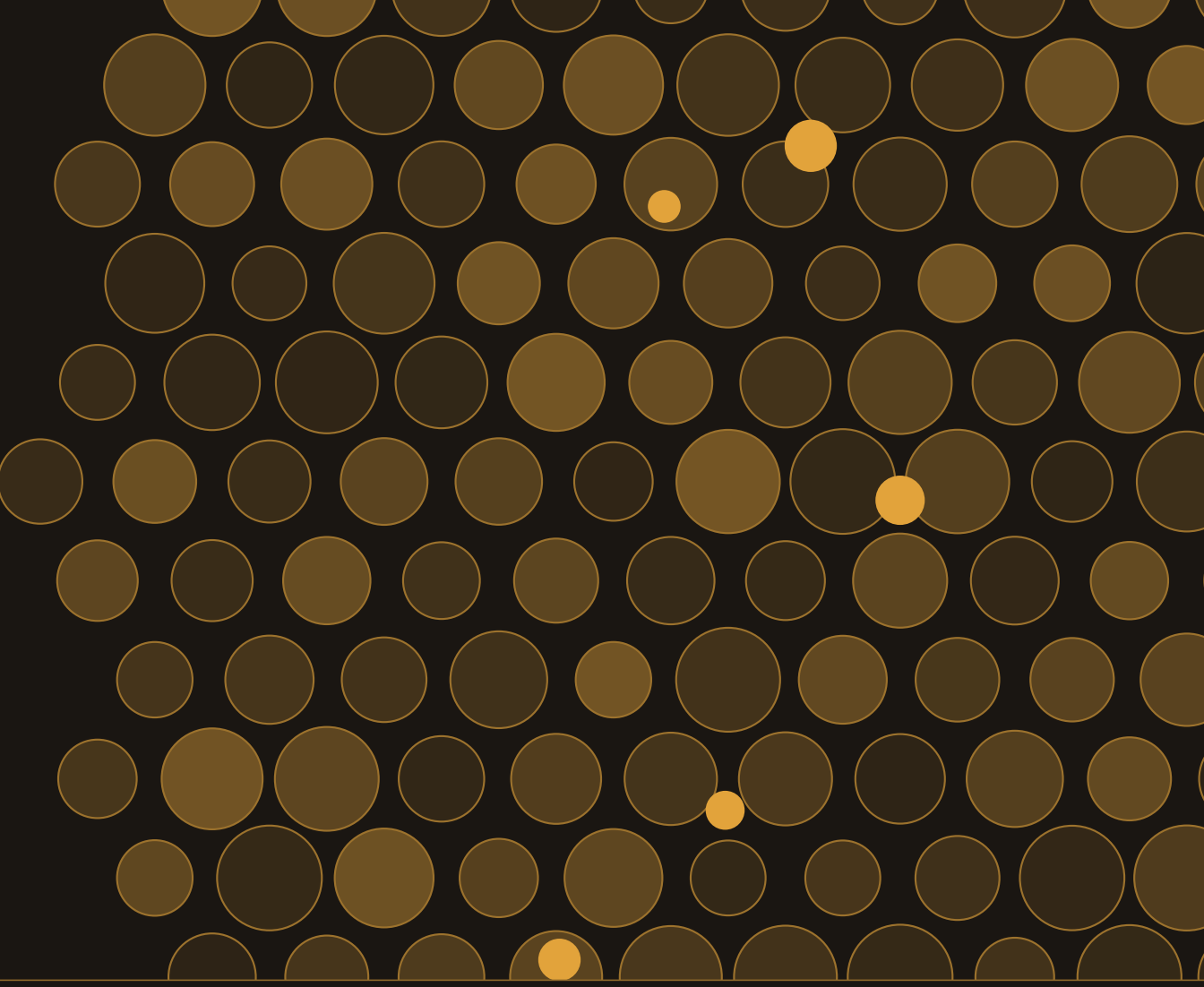
Amargi, the Sumerian term attested in the reforms of Uruinimgina of Lagash and glossed by David Graeber (2011) as the first recorded word for freedom, literally means "return to the mother." It names the regressive-utopian horizon of the text's assault on the archive of debt, binding together the narrator's tears against Robert Paulson's hormonally swollen chest, Tyler's

theology of the absent father, Nietzsche's prophecy of a "second innocence" delivered from debt to the ancestors, and the novel's asylum-heaven in which the narrator is held, fed, and awaited.

The unsaponifiable designates whatever in a subject resists cleavage into commodity and weapon. In *Fight Club* it is Marla. Against the critical consensus that she is the text's most underwritten figure, this dissertation argues that she is its ethical fulcrum, and that her chemical analogue, the sterol fraction from which the steroid hormones of sexual difference are synthesized, specifies with some precision what the reaction cannot render.

0.5 Corpus, Comparanda, and Plan

The comparative apparatus is deliberately wide, because the text is a palimpsest of sources it rarely names and sometimes cannot have known. The method is accordingly genealogical where transmission is documented and structural where it is not, and the distinction is marked throughout. Chapter One reconstructs the ontology of the accumulated subject through Marx, Thoreau, Lukács, Benjamin, Baudrillard, Debord, Augé, Weber, Horkheimer and Adorno, Arendt, Rieff, and Bataille. Chapter Two analyses the lye: the chemical burn as Hegelian negativity and Nietzschean mnemotechnic, the genealogy of debt, Heidegger and Dostoevsky on the mock execution, Kierkegaard's typology of despair, Jünger's "second consciousness," the counterfeit Zen of the blow and the gate, and Tyler as Diogenes, defacer of the currency. Chapter Three develops autothymia through Hegel, Kojève, Fukuyama, and Girard, and situates the narrator–Tyler compound in a genealogy of the double extending from Hogg's *Justified Sinner* to Dick's Horselover Fat. Chapter Four follows the glycerol into Project Mayhem by way of micellar secrecy, Bataillean expenditure, the secret society Acéphale, the Benedictine and Jesuit rules, Nechayev, Dostoevsky's *Demons*, Conrad's *Secret Agent*, and Derrida's archiviolithic death drive. Chapter Five assembles a mythography of the rendered centred on the Promethean division of fat at Mecone, which it identifies as the text's mythic matrix. Chapter Six reads the text against the speculative tradition from Huxley to Ballard and against its cinematic contemporaries and descendants. Chapter Seven formalizes the saponific dialectic, elaborates the three concepts, and reads the final shot as an emulsion. The Conclusion draws the method's consequences for criticism.



01

CHAPTER ONE

Fat

The Accumulated Subject and the Ontology of the Catalogue

STAGE 01 / SUBSTRATE / FAT

The narrator's identity at the opening of *Fight Club* is a fat in the precise sense: an inert reserve of surplus, accumulated rather than expended, whose components are bound to one another by attachments that can be listed, priced, and cleaved. This chapter reconstructs the ontology of that reserve.

1.1 The Catalogue as Dwelling

The film's first ontological thesis is delivered as a camera movement. As the narrator confesses in voice-over that he had become a slave to the "IKEA nesting instinct," the camera tracks through his condominium while each object acquires a floating caption bearing its product name and price, until the apartment is indistinguishable from a catalogue spread. Being, here, is being-catalogued. The narrator's question about which dining set would define him as a person is not hyperbole but ontology: it presupposes that the self is the sum of a series of purchasable differences.

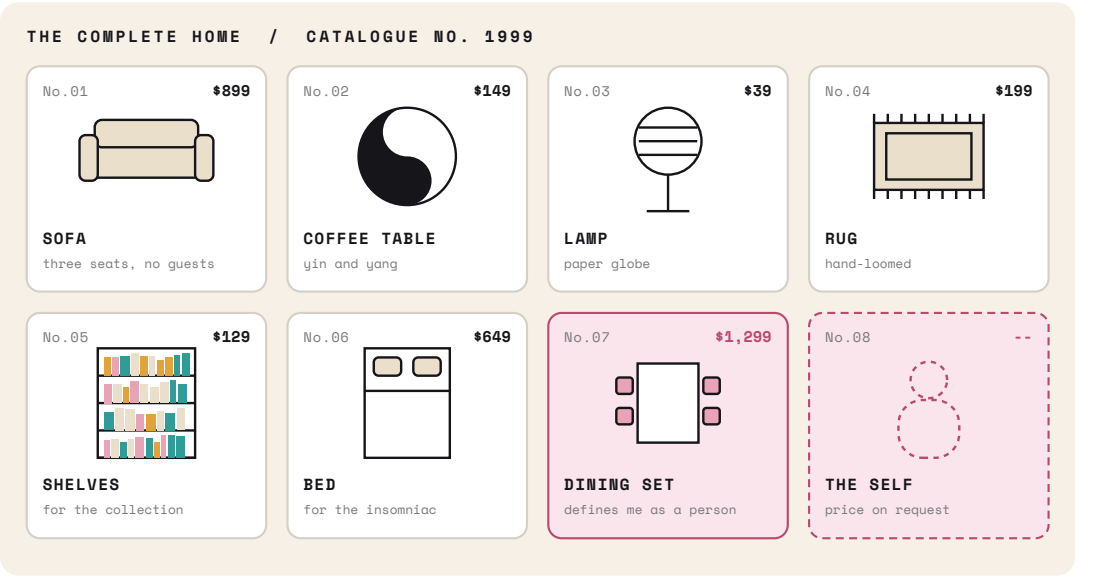


FIG. 3 THE CATALOGUE AS DWELLING

Being as being-catalogued: the condominium as a series of purchasable differences, with one item left unpriced.

> ***Being, here, is being-catalogued.***

Jean Baudrillard's *The System of Objects* (1968) supplies the theory the sequence illustrates. In the system of "ambience," objects shed their use value and acquire sign value through their relations to other objects; the consumer consumes not the object but the system, and personalizes himself through marginal differences that mass production has pre-arranged as choices. Baudrillard's analysis of collecting completes the diagnosis: the final term in every series is the collector, and what one collects is always oneself. The narrator's furniture is a collection whose missing piece is a person.

Walter Benjamin had described the nineteenth-century bourgeois interior as an *étui*, a velvet case into which the private individual pressed the impress of his existence. "Wohnen heißt Spuren hinterlassen," he wrote in the exposé of 1935: to dwell means to leave traces. The flat-packed interior of the 1990s is an *étui* without impressions. Its objects are assembled rather than inherited, and their patina is simulated by the catalogue's styling. Consumer psychology has since given the name "the IKEA effect" (Norton, Mochon, and Ariely 2012) to the inflated valuation that self-assembly produces in its assemblers; the narrator's attachment is that effect elevated into a metaphysics, the self as a flat-pack assembled with an Allen key. Heidegger's distinction in "Building Dwelling Thinking" (1951) between housing and dwelling, between occupying a shelter and sparing, preserving, and abiding in a place, marks what is missing. The novel's figure of the condominium tower as a filing cabinet for widows and young professionals makes the absence architectural: the dwelling is an archive of persons stored by category. Benjamin, who supplied the figure of the étui, also drew Tyler's portrait in advance. In "The Destructive Character" (1931) he set that figure against the étui-man, who seeks his comfort in the case, and observed that the destructive character effaces even the traces of destruction. The explosion of the condominium is the destructive character's first act, and the narrator's amnesia, which erases the record of the one who acts, is its signature.

One further detail repays attention. "Nesting instinct" is the vernacular name for the late-pregnancy urge to prepare a home for an infant, so that the narrator's consumption is figured, from its first articulation, as a phantom gestation without a child. The figure returns in the novel's notorious line, excised from the film at the studio's insistence, in which Marla announces that she wants to have the narrator's abortion, and it returns again, transformed, in this dissertation's account of amargi. The fat the narrator accumulates is maternal before it is masculine.

1.2 Fetish, Vampire, Tool

Tyler's dictum that the things you own end up owning you is the vernacular form of a proposition with a long pedigree. Marx's analysis of the commodity in the first volume of *Capital* (1867) begins from the observation that the commodity, apparently trivial, abounds in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties, and that under its form social relations between persons ap-

pear as relations between things; the fetish is the inversion by which the object governs the subject who made it. In the chapter on the working day Marx's figure for that inversion turns gothic: capital is dead labour that lives, vampire-like, by sucking living labour. The liposuction clinic from whose waste Tyler steals his raw material literalizes the vampire. Its cannula extracts from the bodies of the affluent a surplus that is, in the most literal sense, sedimented consumption, and Tyler returns that surplus to circulation as a luxury good.

The American genealogy of the dictum is older and more intimate. In the "Economy" chapter of *Walden* (1854), Thoreau defined the cost of a thing as the amount of life required to be exchanged for it, and concluded that men "have become the tools of their tools." Emerson's "Self-Reliance" (1841) supplies the axiom on which Tyler's pedagogy rests: "Society everywhere is in conspiracy against the manhood of every one of its members." The next sentence turns the conspiracy into an economy: "Society is a joint-stock company, in which the members agree, for the better securing of his bread to each shareholder, to surrender the liberty and culture of the eater." The narrator's condominium, bought with a recall specialist's salary, is that bargain furnished. Nietzsche read Emerson from adolescence and placed an Emersonian epigraph on the first edition of *The Gay Science* (1882), so that the line running from Concord to Sils Maria to the basement of Lou's Tavern is a documented transmission rather than a critic's construction. Tyler is the Transcendentalist made feral: self-reliance divorced from the Over-Soul, nonconformity divorced from the woods, manhood divorced from the cultivated self Emerson meant it to serve.

Georg Lukács's *History and Class Consciousness* (1923) carried the fetish into the structure of consciousness. Under reification the worker adopts a contemplative stance toward his own activity, observing processes he executes as though they were laws of nature, while time congeals into measurable, divisible space. The narrator's voice-over is reified consciousness given a microphone. He narrates his life in the tone of a product description, contemplates his insomnia as though it were a weather system, and experiences his working hours as units in an actuarial table.

1.3 Insomnia and the Copy

Insomnia, the narrator explains over images of the office photocopier, makes everything distant and unreal, "a copy of a copy of a copy." The phrase condenses a genealogy older than modern theory: Plato had already set the imitator's image third from the truth, a copy of a copy, and modern theory radicalized the charge. Benjamin's essay on mechanical reproduction (1935–36) argued that reproduction withers the aura, the unique presence of the work in time and space; Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) radicalized the argument into the precession of simulacra, in which the copy no longer refers to an original but generates the real it purports to represent. Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967) opened with the thesis that everything

once directly lived has receded into a representation, and defined the spectacle not as a collection of images but as a social relation among persons mediated by images. The narrator lives in what Debord called separation: from his labour, from others, and from himself.

The text's structural twist literalizes the theory. The insomniac does not, in fact, fail to sleep; he sleeps while appearing to wake, and it is during this sleep that Tyler acts. The narrator's waking life is the simulacrum, and his sleep the site of real action. The distinction that insomnia blurs, between waking and dreaming, is the distinction Baudrillard claimed late capitalism had abolished between the real and its simulation; *Fight Club* converts the abolition into the mechanism of its plot.

Marc Augé's *Non-Places* (1992) names the geography of the condition. Airports, aircraft, hotel rooms, and highways are spaces of transit governed by "solitary contractuality," in which identity is verified by ticket and passport and relations are mediated by instructions. The narrator's montage of awakenings in successive airports, his single-serving sugar, cream, and butter, and his "single-serving friends" on flights compose an anthropology of the non-place. Tyler's first appearance in the film's continuity is in the adjacent aircraft seat, and his first lesson is a reading of the emergency card, whose illustrated passengers confront catastrophe "calm as Hindu cows." The safety card is the paradigm of the administered catastrophe: disaster pre-drawn, pre-captioned, and pre-calmed, so that even death arrives as a diagram.

1.4 Actuarial Reason and the Recall Formula

The narrator's profession completes his formation as fat. He is a recall specialist for a car company identified only as "a major one," travelling to the sites of fatal accidents to apply a formula: the number of vehicles in the field, multiplied by the probable rate of failure, multiplied by the average out-of-court settlement, is compared with the cost of a recall, and if the first figure is the lower, no recall is made. The formula is a parable of what Max Weber (1904–05) called rationalization and imaged as the *stahlhartes Gehäuse*, the steel-hard casing of calculable conduct. It is equally an instance of what Horkheimer and Adorno (1944/1947) identified as the self-destruction of enlightenment, in which reason, formalized into calculation, becomes indifferent to ends and reverts to the domination it promised to overcome. Its historical referent is the Ford Pinto controversy of the 1970s, in which the cost-benefit valuation of human life became a public scandal of corporate reason.

Ulrich Beck's *Risk Society* (1986) would describe the narrator as a functionary of risk distribution, and Foucault's lectures on biopolitics (1977–79) as an officer of the population, the statistical object whose life and death are administered through probability. The more exact description is older. Hannah Arendt's report (1963) on the trial of Adolf Eichmann, the SS officer who organized the deportation of Europe's Jews to the killing centres, gave postwar thought the figure that German discourse calls the *Schreibtischtäter*, the desk-murderer whose killing is ac-

complished by memorandum. The narrator is a minor clerk of that type, the comparison being one of structure rather than of scale, administering death by formula, and the text takes care to show that he knows it. When a fellow passenger asks whether such accidents are common, his reply that she would not believe it carries the affectless competence of a man for whom the knowledge has become furniture.

Herman Melville's "Bartleby, the Scrivener" (1853) supplies the counter-figure the office genre has carried ever since. Bartleby's formula, "I would prefer not to," is pure passive refusal, a withdrawal from the circuit of instruction that Gilles Deleuze (1989) and Giorgio Agamben (1993) read as the opening of potentiality, and R. T. Schultz (2011) has traced the line that runs from Bartleby's passive resistance to the terrorist acts of Project Mayhem. The narrator cannot prefer not to. His refusal, when it comes, takes the form of violence against his own body in his superior's office, an inversion of Bartleby's stillness into spectacle that Chapter Two examines. Meanwhile the formula establishes one pole of an oscillation. At work, death is abstracted into numbers; in the support groups to which the narrator is about to turn, dying is concretized into faces. He moves between actuarial abstraction and terminal intimacy without inhabiting either, and the undischarged experience that accumulates between the poles is what this dissertation calls his fat.

1.5 The Therapeutic and the Tourist

The narrator's physician refuses him sleeping pills, recommends valerian root and exercise, and directs him, if he wishes to see real pain, to a testicular cancer support group meeting in a Methodist church. The refusal of the pharmakon inaugurates a pharmaceutical chain that Chapter Five follows to its end. The groups into which the narrator migrates, among them Remaining Men Together, compose the text's portrait of what Philip Rieff called *The Triumph of the Therapeutic* (1966), the displacement of religious man by psychological man, and of what Christopher Lasch called *The Culture of Narcissism* (1979). Their liturgy borrows from the recovery movement of the 1980s and from the mythopoetic men's movement associated with Robert Bly's *Iron John* (1990), whose weeping, embracing men are parodied in the hugs of Remaining Men Together; their guided meditations borrow the "power animal" popularized by Michael Harner's *The Way of the Shaman* (1980). The narrator's power animal, a penguin that instructs him to slide, is the text's comic emblem of New Age detachment.

At the centre of the groups stands Robert "Bob" Paulson, a former bodybuilder whose steroid use preceded testicular cancer, the surgical removal of his testicles, and hormone therapy, and whose chest has consequently grown into breasts. The hypermasculine body has been inverted into a maternal one, and it is against this body that the narrator first weeps and then, for the first time in months, sleeps. The group's very name, Remaining Men Together, announces a motif of castration that the text carries from Bob's body to Project Mayhem's threats against a

police commissioner and, at last, against its own founder. The scene is the text's first figure of amargi. Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) would describe Bob's chest as an abject site at which the boundaries of the masculine body dissolve, a logic Claire Sisco King has extended to the film's whole construction of masculinity under the name of abject-hegemony (2009). The "oceanic feeling" Freud examines in *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) names the boundless state of the nursling to which the narrator returns.

The equilibrium is destroyed by Marla Singer, who attends the groups as the narrator does, without the diseases they address. Dean MacCannell's *The Tourist* (1976) provides the precise concept: *staged authenticity*, the arrangement by which the tourist is admitted to a back region designed to appear unstaged. The narrator is an authenticity tourist, and Marla, whom he calls the big tourist, exposes the staging by duplicating it; her lie, he says, reflects his. In Sartre's analysis of the look in *Being and Nothingness* (1943), the subject surprised at the keyhole is made an object by the gaze of the Other and lives that objectification as shame. Seen, the narrator can no longer weep, and unable to weep he can no longer sleep. Marla is the first Other in the text to recognize him, but the recognition is negative: she recognizes him only as a fraud. The remedy has been poisoned by a witness, and a new remedy, pain, will be required.

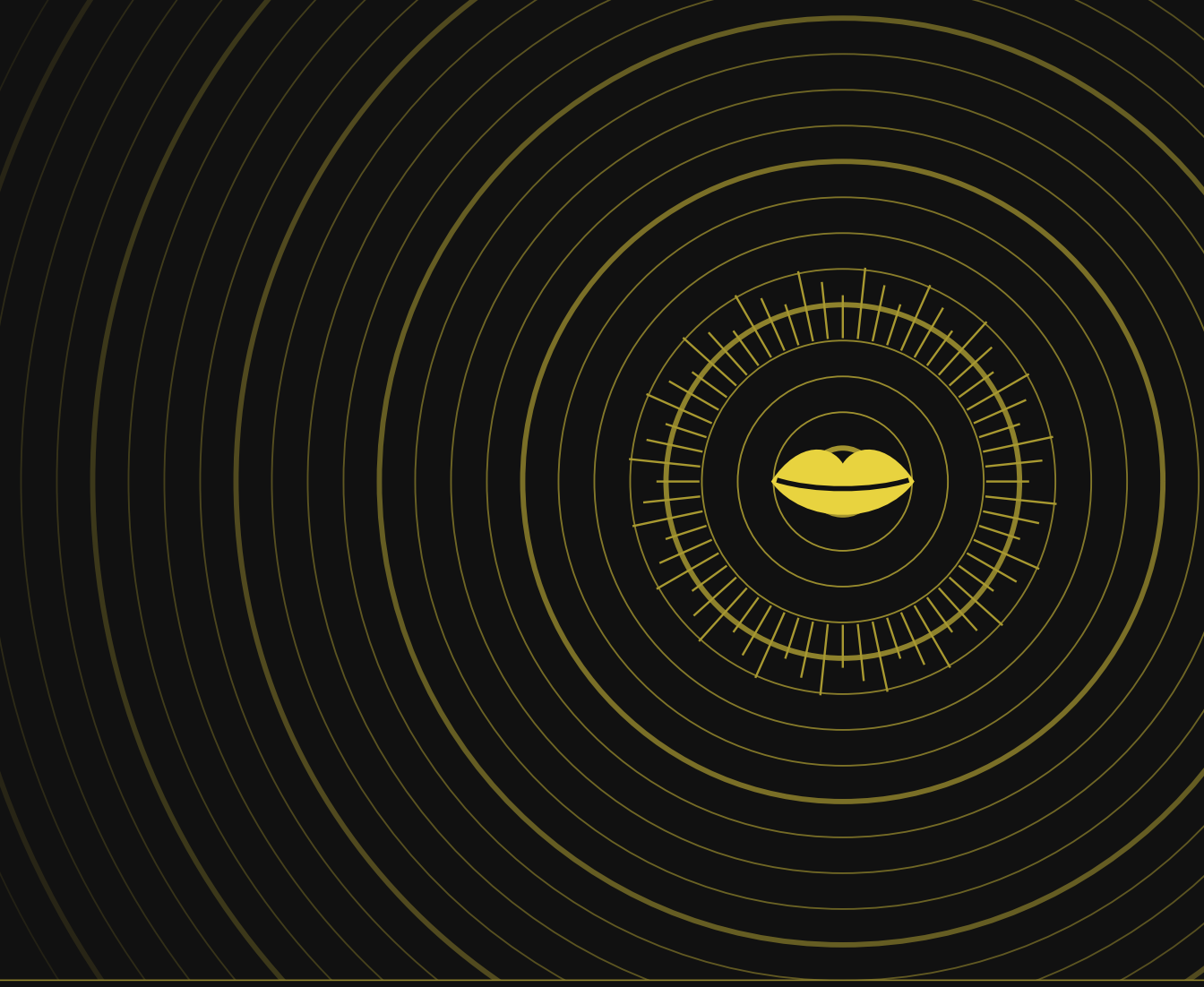
1.6 Fat as Accursed Share

Georges Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) begins from a principle of general economy: a living system receives more energy than it requires to survive, and the excess, if it cannot be absorbed by growth, must be spent without return, gloriously or catastrophically. Fat is the bodily form of the accursed share, energy stored against a scarcity that never arrives. Liposuction is the restricted economy's technique for removing that excess without spending it, and Tyler's soap is that economy's dream of total recycling, in which nothing is lost and surplus returns to the market as a cleansing commodity. Bataille's warning is that the dream fails: what cannot be spent gloriously will be spent catastrophically. The glycerol that saponification liberates is that warning in molecular form.

The image of soap rendered from human bodies also carries a historical charge that no reading of the text can set aside. From 1942 a rumour spread through occupied Europe that the Nazi state, which murdered some six million European Jews, was making soap from its victims' bodies. It attached itself to bars stamped RIF, the initials of the Reich agency for industrial fat supply, which were misread as standing for "pure Jewish fat," and camp personnel used the story to torment prisoners. Historians, among them Yehuda Bauer and Yad Vashem's archives director Shmuel Krakowski, have rejected the claim of industrial production, and soap tested by the United States Holocaust Memorial Museum contained no human fat. The one documented case remains disputed. At Nuremberg in 1946 Soviet prosecutors alleged that the Danzig Anatomical Institute under Rudolf Spanner had conducted semi-industrial experiments in making soap

from human bodies. In 2006 prosecutors of Poland's Institute of National Remembrance concluded that soap had indeed been made there from human fat, in quantities of perhaps ten to a hundred kilograms, and used to clean dissecting rooms, while finding no crime committed on the premises. The historian Joachim Neander, followed by researchers connected with the same institute, has argued that the substance was a by-product of preparing anatomical specimens and that the Holocaust-related claims made about Danzig are a myth. The rumour's persistence is itself evidence of what soap made from people signifies: the point at which two kinds of rendering meet, the commodity form, which renders concrete bodies and labour into exchangeable abstraction, and the camp, which Agamben calls the hidden matrix of modern political space and in which persons were reduced to matter. Tyler's first product stands at that intersection. The fascist overtones that critics found in Project Mayhem are therefore not a later accretion; they are already present in the soap, and Chapter Seven argues that the saponific model explains why the critique of the commodity arrives accompanied by its fascist residue.

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place and purity as the maintenance of classificatory order. Human fat taken from a medical waste container is the abject par excellence, matter at once intimate and expelled, and Tyler's operation converts it into the very instrument of purification, so that the abject becomes the cleanser. The circuit is gendered as well. Tyler's boast that he sells rich women their own fat back to them describes an economy in which women's bodily surplus is rendered by men's labour and repurchased by women as luxury. The narrator's own surplus is the thymotic energy that a life of catalogue, nonplace, and formula has given him no means to spend. Chapter Two describes the agent that cleaves it.



02

CHAPTER TWO

Lye

Pain, Memory, Debt, and the Caustic Negative

STAGE 02 / REAGENT / LYE, NaOH

Tyler Durden enters the narrator's constitution as a caustic: an agent whose function is not to add a content but to cleave the bonds by which existing contents hold together. This chapter traces the genealogy of that agency, from Hegel's negativity and Nietzsche's mnemotechnic through Heidegger, Kierkegaard, and Jünger to the counterfeit Zen and the Cynicism through which Tyler administers it.

2.1 The Kiss and the Burn

The text's primal scene of initiation takes place in the house on Paper Street. Tyler kisses the back of the narrator's hand, wets the imprint, and pours lye onto it, so that the burn takes the shape of the lips. The narrator tries to escape into the guided-meditation imagery of the support groups, the cave and the penguin, and Tyler slaps him back into his body, insisting that he attend to the pain, that this is the greatest moment of his life and he is somewhere else, missing it. Only when the narrator consents to remain does Tyler pour vinegar over the wound to neutralize the base.

The scene is a neutralization reaction staged as a sacrament, and it is legible in Hegel's own vocabulary. In the Preface to the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), Hegel wrote that the life of Spirit is not the life that shrinks from death and keeps itself untouched by devastation, but the life that endures death and maintains itself in it; Spirit wins its truth only by finding itself in absolute dismemberment, and it is this power only "indem er dem Negativen ins Angesicht schaut, bei ihm verweilt," by looking the negative in the face and tarrying with it; this tarrying, Hegel adds, is the magic power that converts the negative into being. Tyler's pedagogy is a crude wager on that magic: pain held long enough will turn into a self. The guided meditation is the flight from the negative into an imaginary refuge; Tyler's demand is *Verweilen beim Negativen*. The vinegar, an acid that neutralizes the base, completes the figure in the register of Hegel's logic, where chemism names the process in which opposed objects are neutralized into a product. The narrator is permitted the neutral product only after he has tarried.

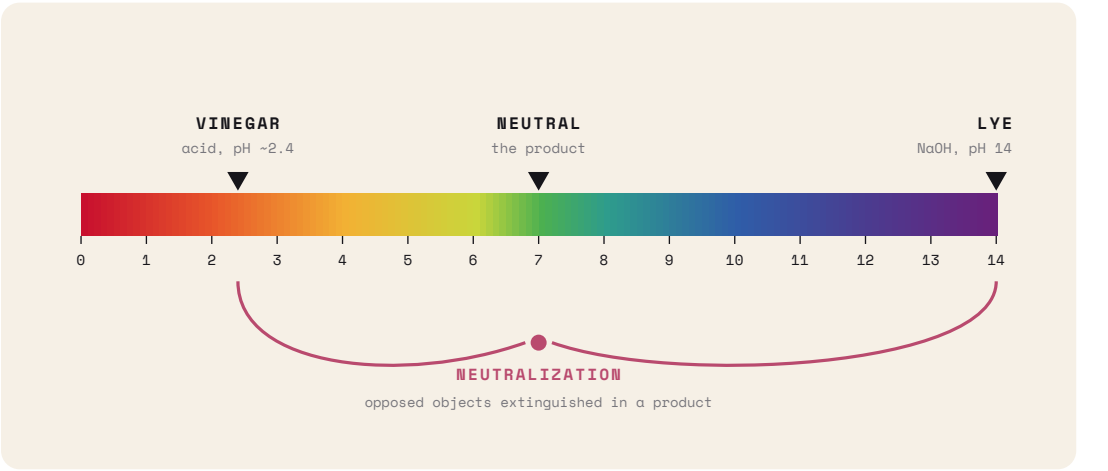


FIG. 4 NEUTRALIZATION

Lye at pH 14 meets vinegar at about pH 2.4. In Hegel's terms this is chemism: opposed objects extinguished in a neutral product.

Lacanian theory names the burn's other dimension. The Real is what resists symbolization absolutely, and *jouissance* is the enjoyment beyond the pleasure principle that the subject undergoes as pain. Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) had located in the compulsive repetition of unpleasure the trace of a drive older than pleasure, and the scar is that drive's signature: a wound that repeats the kiss as injury and keeps it present on the body. Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) supplies the narrative archetype. Its apparatus inscribes the condemned man's sentence into his flesh, and illumination, the officer insists, arrives at the sixth hour, when the man begins to decipher the script with his wounds. Tyler's kiss is an inscription of the same order: the master's signature on the body of the initiate, at once the lover's kiss, the kiss of the initiating order, and the kiss of Judas.

2.2 Burned In: Nietzsche's Mnemotechnic and the Genealogy of Debt

The Second Essay of Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) asks how an animal capable of active forgetting was bred into an animal capable of promising, and answers with a mnemotechnic: "Man brennt Etwas ein, damit es im Gedächtniss bleibt: nur was nicht aufhört, weh zu thun, bleibt im Gedächtniss." Something is burned in so that it stays in the memory; only what does not cease to hurt stays in the memory. The chemical burn is this sentence performed. Yet the text's twist inverts the result. The narrator does not remember being Tyler: the mnemotechnic succeeds on the body, which keeps the scar, and fails in the mind, which disowns the act. The scar is an archive the subject refuses to consult.

> *The scar is an archive the subject refuses to consult.*

Nietzsche's genealogy then binds memory to debt. *Schuld*, guilt, derives from *Schulden*, debts; the oldest relation is that between creditor and debtor, and the creditor's original compensation was the right to inflict pain, the pleasure of cruelty accepted as payment. The sequence Nietzsche reconstructs, in which pain makes memory, memory makes the promise, the promise makes the debt, and the debt makes guilt, is the sequence *Fight Club* follows from the burned hand to the credit-card towers. The text's final target is the institution in which the creditor–debtor relation has been abstracted into a database.

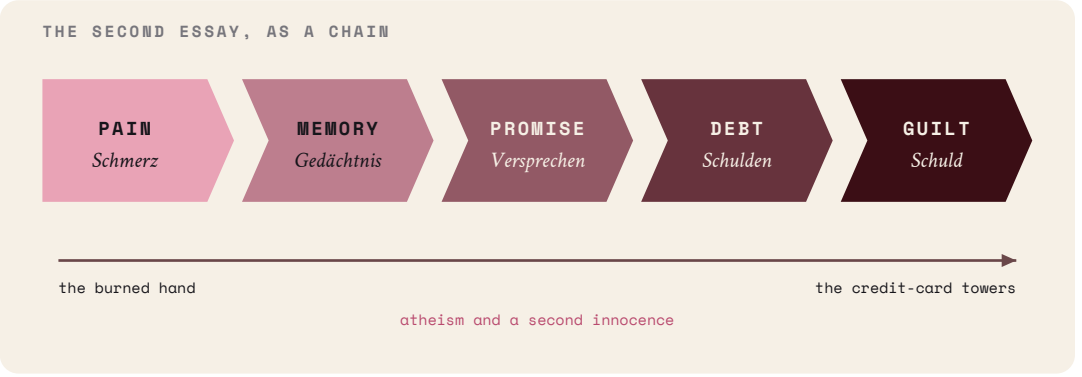


FIG. 5 THE GENEALOGY OF DEBT

Nietzsche's sequence in the Second Essay, which the text follows from the burned hand to the credit-card towers.

Section 16 of the essay describes the internalization of man: every instinct that cannot discharge itself outward turns inward, and from this *Verinnerlichung* the bad conscience and the "soul" are born. The self-beating scene externalizes the bad conscience as spectacle. Summoned by his superior, the narrator beats himself bloody in the superior's office so that, when security arrives, the superior appears to be his assailant; he extracts a salary for staying away and uses the money to expand fight club. Slavoj Žižek's reading of the scene, set out in *Revolution at the Gates* (2002), where he praises the film as a rare Hollywood achievement, and restated in Sophie Fiennes's documentary *The Pervert's Guide to Cinema* (2006), treats it as a parable of emancipation: servitude is sustained by the servant's attachment to the master, and the first act of liberation is an assault on that attachment in oneself. In Nietzschean terms, the aggression that had turned inward to form the conscience is turned outward again, but by way of the self, so that the narrator's body becomes the medium through which internalized cruelty is converted into leverage.

The genealogy culminates in theology. Nietzsche traces the debt owed to the ancestors swelling into the debt owed to the gods and finally into the infinite debt owed to the Christian God, the maximal creditor; he speculates that atheism might release mankind from the feeling of indebtedness to its origin, and concludes that "Atheismus und eine Art zweiter Unschuld gehören zu einander": atheism and a kind of second innocence belong together. Tyler's sermon during the burn is a vulgate of the passage. "Our fathers were our models for God," he observes; if the fathers abandoned their sons, God may not like them, may never have wanted them, may hate them; the men he addresses are therefore "God's unwanted children," released from damnation and redemption alike. The renunciation of the paternal creditor is the theological premise of the assault on the financial one. Nietzsche also imagines a creditor grown powerful enough to let his debtors go unpunished, a self-overcoming of justice that calls itself mercy. Project Mayhem's erasure of the debt record is the counterfeit of that mercy: a jubilee seized by the debtors rather than granted by the creditor.

2.3 Being-Toward-Death at Gunpoint

The most philosophically explicit scene in the film takes place behind a convenience store. Tyler, whom the viewer will later understand to be the narrator, drags the clerk Raymond K. Hessel into the alley, holds a gun to his head, takes his driver's licence, learns that he abandoned his studies in veterinary medicine, and promises to kill him if, within weeks, he is not on his way to becoming a veterinarian. The narrator's horror is answered with a beatitude: the next day will be the most beautiful of Raymond's life, and even his breakfast will taste better than any meal they have known.

The scene is a coercive staging of the analysis of death in Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927). Everyday existence, governed by *das Man*, the anonymous "they," tranquillizes death into an event that befalls "one" and never me; authentic existence anticipates death as one's ownmost, non-relational, certain, and indefinite possibility, and this anticipation individualizes Dasein and frees it for its own potentiality-for-being. Tyler supplies the anticipation by force. He converts death's indefiniteness into a deadline, and in so doing exposes the contradiction latent in every pedagogy of authenticity: an authenticity imposed by another is heteronomous by definition. Adorno's *The Jargon of Authenticity* (1964) argued that the postwar cult of *Eigentlichkeit* ennobled submission and sanctified the given; Tyler's alley reveals the violence the jargon conceals.

Dostoevsky supplies the historical and literary archetype. On 22 December 1849 members of the Petrashevsky circle, Dostoevsky among them, were led onto Semyonovsky Square, read their sentences of death, and reprieved at the last moment by a pardon arranged in advance. In *The Idiot* (1868–69), Prince Myshkin recounts the experience of a condemned man who resolved, if spared, to turn every minute into an age and squander nothing, and who, once spared,

squandered a great many minutes. Dostoevsky's scepticism about the durability of the mock execution's illumination is precisely the scepticism *Fight Club* withholds: the film never discloses whether Raymond became a veterinarian. Tolstoy's *The Death of Ivan Ilyich* (1886), whose hero learns in dying that his correct life was the wrong one, and the Stoic meditation on death in Seneca and Marcus Aurelius complete the lineage. Against Epicurus's maxim that death is nothing to us, Tyler insists that death must be everything to us. The narrator's own maxim, that on a long enough timeline the survival rate for everyone drops to zero, joins the actuarial and the existential in a single sentence: being-toward-death expressed as a survival statistic, the recall formula turned upon the self.

2.4 Despair in Weakness, Despair in Defiance

Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849), published under the pseudonym Anti-Climacus, defines the self as a relation that relates itself to itself and despair as a misrelation within that self-relation. Its typology distinguishes the despair that is ignorant of having a self from conscious despair, and divides conscious despair into two forms: in despair not to will to be oneself, the despair of weakness, and in despair to will to be oneself, the despair of defiance. The narrator embodies the first. He wishes to be anyone but himself: Cornelius, Rupert, Travis, the aliases under which he frequents the groups; the owner of the right dining set; a man whose identity is borrowed from objects and from the dying.

Tyler embodies the second. The defiant self, Anti-Climacus writes, wills to be itself by constructing itself, acknowledging no power that established it; it would be its own master absolutely, and its mastery is that of a king without a country, ruling over nothing and able at any moment to begin again, arbitrarily, from nothing. When Tyler explains, in the hotel room of the revelation, that he is everything the narrator wishes to be, in looks, in sex, in capability, and above all in being free in every way the narrator is not, he describes Kierkegaard's experimenting self with precision. The split between narrator and Tyler is therefore not only a psychiatric event. It is the dialectic of despair externalized into two persons sharing one body, weakness and defiance each making the other possible. Kierkegaard's remedy, faith, the self resting transparently in the power that established it, is exactly what Tyler's theology of the hostile father forecloses. Chapter Seven argues that the text substitutes for faith a relation to another finite self: not the power that established the narrator, but the woman who witnessed him.

2.5 The Second Consciousness

No twentieth-century writer theorized pain with more consequence than Ernst Jünger. *Storm of Steel* (1920) aestheticized the experience of the front; "Total Mobilization" (1930) described the conversion of whole societies into energy for war; *The Worker* (1932) announced a new human

Gestalt, a type that supersedes the individual and is formed by technology, uniformity, and discipline. "On Pain" (1934) made the decisive claim: the measure of a person and of an epoch is their relation to pain, and the modern type has developed what Jünger called a "second consciousness," through which it regards its own body as an object, a capacity he found exemplified in photography's dispassionate record of suffering.

The narrator's dissociation is Jünger's second consciousness become pathology. The film literally shows two bodies where the diegesis contains one; the narrator watches himself fight, burn, and command, and his voice-over is the cold consciousness that records the injuries of a body it does not entirely own. The space monkeys, shaved, uniformed, and stripped of names, are Jünger's *Typus* in miniature, and Project Mayhem's absorption of waiters, projectionists, mechanics, and policemen into a single front is total mobilization conducted from below.

Jünger's later writings mark the alternatives between which the text oscillates. *The Forest Passage* (1951) describes the *Waldgänger*, the individual who withdraws into the forest to resist the Leviathan; Tyler's pastoral vision of elk hunted through forests grown over Manhattan is a *Waldgang* imagined as the outcome of a demolition rather than a withdrawal. *Eumeswil* (1977) distinguishes the anarchist, who seeks to destroy the state, from the Anarch, who has withdrawn sovereignty into himself and needs neither to destroy nor to obey. Tyler is the anarchist. The narrator at the end is neither anarchist nor Anarch but a third figure that Jünger's typology does not foresee: a man holding another person's hand.

2.6 The Counterfeit Koan

Tyler's pedagogy borrows the forms of Zen. The Chan master Linji (d. 866) taught through shouts and blows and told his students to kill the Buddha if they met him; Japanese monastic practice institutionalized the *keisaku*, the stick with which the drowsy meditator is struck. Tyler's command to stop trying to control everything and let go, issued as he takes his hands from the wheel of a car speeding into oncoming traffic, and his teaching that only after losing everything is one free to do anything, are debased versions of the doctrines of non-attachment and emptiness. After the crash, his verdict that they have just had a "near-life experience" is a koan in the form of a pun.

The text's most precise borrowing has gone unremarked. Applicants to Project Mayhem stand on the porch of the house on Paper Street for three days, insulted and refused, before they are admitted. The ordeal reproduces *niwa-zume*, the entrance trial of the Japanese Zen monastery, in which the postulant waits at the gate, is repeatedly rejected, and must persist for days before *tanga-zume*, a further period of solitary sitting, precedes admission. Chapter Four shows that the Rule of Saint Benedict prescribes a parallel trial. D. T. Suzuki's mediation of Zen to the West (1938, revised 1959) included an influential account of Zen's affinity with the sword; Alan Watts's "Beat Zen, Square Zen, and Zen" (1958) distinguished the Beats' licence from the discip-

line it imitated; and Brian Victoria's *Zen at War* (1997) documented the support given by Japanese Zen institutions to imperial Japan's wars in China and the Pacific, including the doctrine that selfless obedience unto death fulfilled the teaching of no-self. The historical passage from *anattā* to sacrificial nationalism is the passage Tyler's pedagogy accomplishes in a few months. The space monkey is selflessness converted into instrumentality: no-self as a weapon.

2.7 Defacing the Currency

Diogenes of Sinope, according to Diogenes Laërtius, was the son of a money-changer exiled for adulterating the coinage, and received from an oracle the charge to *paracharattein to nomisma*, to deface the currency, a phrase that turns on the kinship between *nomisma*, coin, and *nomos*, convention. The Cynic's vocation was the overturning of convention in the name of nature: he lived in a storage jar, performed in public the acts others hid, and called himself a citizen of the world. Tyler is a Cynic in every particular. He urinates into the soup of a luxury hotel, splices single frames of pornography into family films, inhabits a ruin, and directs his movement toward the literal defacement of the currency, the destruction of the record of credit.

Peter Sloterdijk's *Critique of Cynical Reason* (1983) distinguishes this plebeian, embodied, insolent *Kynismus* from modern *Zynismus*, the enlightened false consciousness of those who know what they do and do it anyway. The recall formula is *Zynismus* perfected: the corporation knows that its product kills and has calculated the price. Tyler's *Kynismus* is the answer of the body to the formula. Mikhail Bakhtin's account of carnival in *Rabelais and His World* (1965) names its resources: the grotesque body, the material lower stratum, urine and excrement as agents of regenerative laughter. But Tyler's carnival is held in a basement under a rule of silence, without the marketplace community and without the laughter that for Bakhtin made carnival regenerative. It is carnival without renewal, the grotesque body enlisted for discipline, and so already on its way to becoming the uniform it mocks.



03

CHAPTER THREE

The Amphiphile

Autothymia and the Struggle for Recognition

STAGE 03 / STRUCTURE / AMPHIPHILE

The narrator and Tyler are not two subjects but the two ends of one molecule, and the drama of their relation is the drama of a recognition that cannot be granted, because there is no one outside the molecule to grant it.

3.1 The First Fight

After the destruction of his condominium, the narrator telephones Tyler, meets him at a bar, and, in the parking lot afterwards, receives the request on which the text turns: Tyler asks the narrator to hit him as hard as he can. They fight without stakes, without an object, and without a victor, and afterwards share a beer in a state of elation.

Chapter IV of Hegel's *Phenomenology* begins from the claim that self-consciousness exists in and for itself only by being recognized by another self-consciousness. Each seeks the death of the other and stakes its own life; the one who prefers life to recognition becomes the bondsman, the one who stakes his life becomes the lord, and the lord's victory proves hollow, since recognition from a bondsman is recognition from a thing. Kojève's lectures (1933–39) radicalized the account into an anthropology: human desire is desire for the desire of another, and the fight to the death for pure prestige, undertaken for no biological end, is the act through which the human emerges from the animal.

The parking-lot fight is a fight for pure prestige, and it is anthropogenic in effect: both men experience it as the beginning of a life. But it departs from the Hegelian scene in two respects that determine everything that follows. First, it is requested, so that the reciprocity Hegel places at the end of the dialectic is installed at its beginning by contract; the struggle is conducted under rules, and the rules of fight club will be the bourgeois form of the life-and-death struggle. Second, as the retrospective montage of the revelation will show, the narrator was alone in the parking lot, hitting himself. The anthropogenic act is autothymic. The beer that follows parodies the moment at which Hegel announces the arrival of Spirit, "Ich, das Wir, und Wir, das Ich ist," the I that is We and the We that is I. Fight club will be the counterfeit of that We.

> *The anthropogenic act is autothymic.*

3.2 Kojève, Fukuyama, and the Middle Children of History

Kojève held that history, as the sequence of struggles for recognition, had reached its essential end with Napoleon at Jena, and that post-historical man would either revert to a satisfied animality or, as he proposed in a note written after a visit to Japan in 1959 and added to a later edi-

tion of the lectures, live in the pure forms of snobbery. Francis Fukuyama's *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992), developed from his essay of 1989, reread the end of the Cold War through Kojève. Liberal democracy, Fukuyama argued, was the terminal form of government because it satisfied *thymos*, the desire for recognition, in its egalitarian form, *isothymia*; but he feared that *megalothymia*, the desire to be recognized as superior, would find no outlet in a world of peace and prosperity, and he predicted that men denied a just cause would struggle against the just order itself, out of boredom, for the sake of struggle.

Tyler's oration in the basement is that prediction delivered from below. He sees in fight club the strongest and smartest men who have ever lived, reduced to pumping gas and waiting tables, "slaves with white collars" chasing cars and clothes; they are "the middle children of history," with no Great War and no Great Depression, raised by television to believe they would become millionaires and stars and slowly learning that they will not. Palahniuk's novel appeared four years after Fukuyama's book and answers its central anxiety with a scenario: thymos at the end of history does not disappear; it is privatized, secreted in basements, and then mobilized. Fukuyama later reached a version of the same conclusion: *Identity* (2018) rebuilt his account of contemporary politics around thymos, "the part of the soul that craves recognition of dignity," arguing that much of what presents itself as economic anxiety is a demand for recognition and that resentment at the bottom of the ladder concerns lost dignity more than lost resources, a diagnosis that fits the online subcultures that took Tyler as their emblem.

Fukuyama took his title from Nietzsche's *Zarathustra* (1883–85), whose last men have invented happiness and blink. Tyler presents himself as the antithesis of the last man, a counterfeit *Übermensch*, and the counterfeit is exposed by the text's most discussed irony. On a bus the narrator studies an underwear advertisement and asks whether that is what a man looks like; Tyler laughs, dismissing self-improvement as masturbation and recommending self-destruction instead. But Tyler's own body, the body of Brad Pitt in 1999, is the body in the advertisement. The thymotic ideal and the commodity ideal coincide: the revolt against advertising wears advertising's face. Fincher came to feature filmmaking from commercials and music videos, having co-founded a production company named, without apparent irony, Propaganda Films, and he has said that Starbucks cups appear throughout the film, "in every shot," not out of animus toward the company but because it was too successful. The film knows that its critique is printed on the packaging.

3.3 Autothymia

This dissertation proposes the term *autothymia* for the structural condition in which the thymotic demand for recognition, finding no adequate external addressee, produces from within the subject a second locus of self-consciousness whose function is to grant, withhold, and contest recognition. Four conditions make it possible. The first is the single-serving other: in

the non-places of consumer society others are present only as functions, contractual, interchangeable, and incapable of the reciprocity recognition requires. The second is the post-historical evacuation of stakes, the absence of the war, revolution, or depression in which earlier generations risked their lives. The third is the failure of the paternal Other, what Lacan called the Name-of-the-Father, the symbolic authority that inscribes the subject in a lineage. The text's fathers have absconded: the narrator's own, he tells Tyler, started a new family in a new city every six years, and Tyler's gloss is that he was setting up franchises. Mike Chopra-Gant has made this paternal absence the key to the film's mediated masculinities (2013). The fourth is the merely negative recognition offered by Marla, who sees the narrator only as a fraud.

Two bodies of work sharpen the concept. Axel Honneth's *The Struggle for Recognition* (1992) reconstructed the young Hegel's theory, with help from George Herbert Mead, as three forms of recognition, love, rights, and solidarity or social esteem, each shadowed by a form of disrespect, of which the most elementary is physical maltreatment, the violation of the body that injures the basic self-confidence love provides. Fight club inverts that first form: physical violation, consented to and returned, becomes a counterfeit of the recognition the narrator lacks in all three spheres, which is why the bruises are carried into the office like credentials. Krister Friday's Lacanian reading (2003) had already observed that the narrator frames his wounded masculinity in historical terms, seeking recognition from History itself as the Other. Autothymia names the next step: when History, too, declines to answer, the subject manufactures the Other that will.

Autothymia has a dynamics. Its first moment is splitting, enabled by the insomnia that conceals the fugue. Its second is inversion: the produced Other becomes the master, and the narrator becomes the bondsman of his own projection, serving, cleaning up after, and envying the self he invented in order to be recognized. Its third is escalation. Because recognition, for Hegel, can be granted only by an independent self-consciousness, an internal Other can only mirror; the demand is never met and must be renewed by ever more extreme tests, the burn, the crash, the mock execution. Its fourth is collectivization. The autothymic loop externalizes itself as an institution in which a crowd of men recognize Tyler and, through Tyler, the narrator; the space monkeys are prostheses of recognition, and the narrator's jealousy of them is the jealousy of a man watching strangers grant his double the recognition he cannot grant himself. Its fifth and terminal moment is autoimmunity, examined in Chapter Seven: the defence turns against the organism it was produced to protect, and it can be ended only by a wound to the body that hosts both.

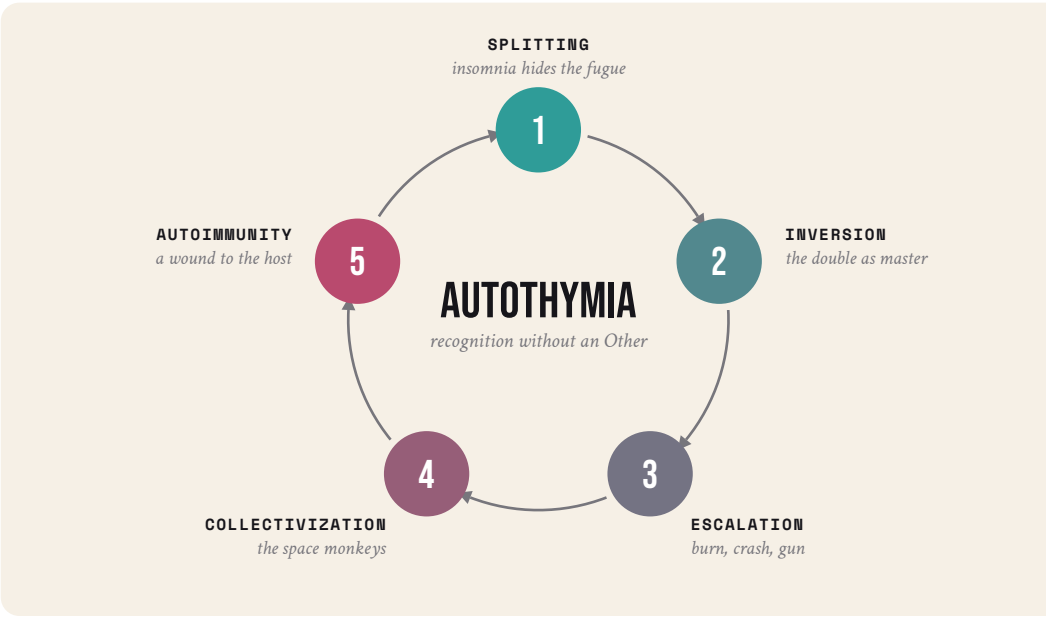


FIG. 6 AUTOTHYMIA

The five moments of a recognition produced from within: splitting, inversion, escalation, collectivization, autoimmunity.

Hegel's own sequence anticipates these dynamics. After lordship and bondage, self-consciousness passes through Stoicism, which withdraws into indifference toward the world; Scepticism, which negates every determinate content; and the *unhappy consciousness*, which knows itself as doubled and contradictory, divided between a changeable and an unchangeable self, and seeks unity through a mediator and through self-mortification. The narrator's catalogue-life is a consumer Stoicism, an indifference furnished in birch veneer; Tyler's litany of negations is Scepticism; the split itself is the unhappy consciousness; and the ascetic programme of Project Mayhem, its insults, renunciations, and humiliations, is the self-mortification by which the unhappy consciousness seeks the unchangeable. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) supplies the last term. The primal father is killed by the band of brothers, whose guilt institutes the law. Tyler is a primal father produced by sons who had none, and the narrator will kill him; what law can be founded on that killing is the question of the final chapter.

3.4 Mimesis and the Monstrous Double

René Girard's *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel* (1961) argued that desire is mimetic: the subject desires an object because a model, or mediator, desires it. Where the mediator is distant, as Amadís is from Don Quixote, mediation is external and peaceable; where the mediator is near, mediation is internal, the model becomes a rival, and subject and model converge into doubles. *Fight Club* drives internal mediation to its limit, at which the distance between subject and mediator is

zero because the mediator is a projection. The objects of the rivalry follow. One is Marla, with whom Tyler sleeps while the narrator listens through the walls. The other is Tyler's favour itself, which the narrator sees bestowed on the beautiful young recruit called Angel Face. The narrator's destruction of Angel Face's face in the basement, which he explains by saying that he felt like destroying something beautiful, is mimetic violence in its purest form, directed at the rival for the mediator's love.

Violence and the Sacred (1972) extended the theory to the origin of culture. In a sacrificial crisis differences collapse, doubles proliferate, and reciprocal violence spreads by contagion until it converges, unanimously, upon a surrogate victim whose expulsion restores order; at the height of the crisis participants perceive a *monstrous double*, a hallucinatory fusion of self and other. Project Mayhem enacts the crisis: men made identical by shaved heads and black clothes, the collapse of differences institutionalized as uniform. Its first victim is Bob, killed by police during a sabotage mission; its decisive victim is Tyler, expelled by the narrator's self-inflicted shot. The *pharmakos* is the double.

Girard's *Dostoevsky: From the Double to Unity* (1963) proposed that Dostoevsky's fiction moves from the obsessive doubling of the early works toward a conversion in which the hero renounces the mimetic model. The narrator's conversion takes both forms: the violent expulsion of the double, and a renunciation that takes the shape of an outstretched hand. Girard would insist that only the second resolves the crisis. *Fight Club* refuses to choose, and the refusal is the subject of Chapter Seven.

3.5 A Genealogy of the Double

Otto Rank's study of the double (1914) found in the doppelgänger an originally protective figure, an insurance against death that later reverses into death's harbinger, and traced it to narcissism. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) read the double as a surmounted animistic belief returning as uncanny repetition. Jung's Shadow, the repressed and inferior portion of the personality, adds the danger that an ego failing to integrate the Shadow will be possessed by it. Tyler is each of these at once: insurance against the narrator's nullity, harbinger of his death, return of the repressed, and the Shadow by which he is possessed.

The literary genealogy is richer than criticism has acknowledged, and its most exact member is James Hogg's *The Private Memoirs and Confessions of a Justified Sinner* (1824). Robert Wringhim, raised in an antinomian Calvinism that assures him he is one of the elect and therefore incapable of sin, meets Gil-Martin, a stranger who resembles him and can assume any shape, and under his influence commits murder; he loses months of his life in a fugue during which witnesses attribute to him crimes he cannot remember, and he ends by suicide. Every structural element of *Fight Club* is present: the double who shapes the deeds, the amnesia, the witnesses who attest to acts the narrator does not recall, the theological licence for transgression, and the memoir re-

covered after the catastrophe. Even the theology is inverted with precision. Wringhim's crimes are licensed by election; Tyler's men are licensed by rejection, freed from the law not because God has chosen them but because he never wanted them. This dissertation proposes the *Justified Sinner* as *Fight Club*'s truest structural ancestor.

Poe's "William Wilson" (1839) inverts the outcome. Wilson's double is his conscience, interrupting each vice, and when Wilson stabs him the dying double declares that in killing him Wilson has murdered himself. The narrator of *Fight Club* shoots himself in order to kill a double who is the opposite of conscience, and survives. Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) contributes a chemical moral of startling relevance: Jekyll's final statement records that the salt on which his transformation depended had been impure, that a fresh and pure supply failed, and that "it was that unknown impurity which lent efficacy to the draught." The double is produced by an impurity in the reagent. The narrator's impurity, his fraudulent tourism among the dying, is precisely what Marla detects, and it catalyses Tyler.

Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846) gives the double an office: Golyadkin's replica usurps his place at work and wins the favour of his superiors, the bureaucratic double for which the narrator's office life has prepared him. Conrad's "The Secret Sharer" (1910) gives him a cabin: a young captain conceals a fugitive who has killed a man and who resembles him, and secures his own command through the identification.

Borges gives the double a theology. In "The Theologians" (1947), two churchmen pursue a lifelong enmity until one learns, after death, that for God they formed a single person; in "Borges and I" (1960), the private writer cannot say which of the two has written the page. The retrospective montage of *Fight Club*, which replays remembered scenes with Tyler subtracted, is the Borgesian view from God: the two were always one.

Philip K. Dick supplies the double's late-capitalist form. In *A Scanner Darkly* (1977), Bob Arctor is an undercover narcotics agent who, concealed in a "scramble suit" that dissolves his appearance into a flicker of fragments, is assigned to surveil himself; the drug he investigates severs the hemispheres of his brain, and he ends as a labourer on a rehabilitation farm that secretly grows the drug, the therapeutic institution manufacturing the pathology it treats. In *VALIS* (1981), the narrator Phil splits off a second self named Horselover Fat, a literal rendering of his own name (*Philip*, lover of horses; German *dick*, fat), and confesses at the outset that he is Horselover Fat, writing in the third person for the sake of objectivity. The confession could serve as *Fight Club*'s epigraph. Dick's double is, by name, Fat.

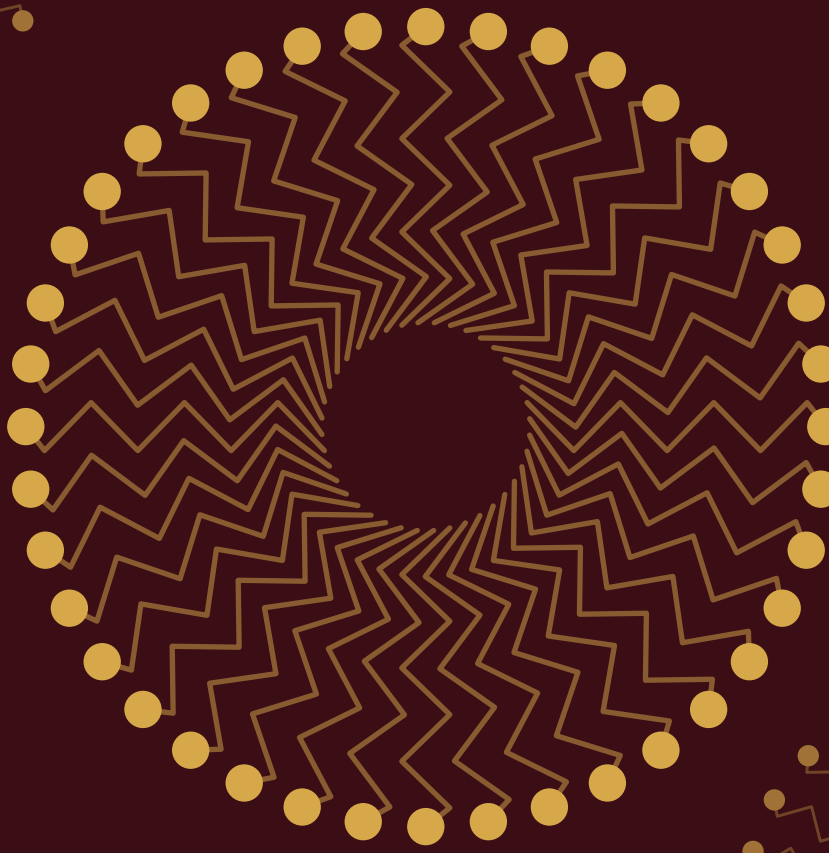
3.6 The Amphiphilic Subject

The revelation arrives when a bartender in a distant city greets the narrator as Mr Durden, and Tyler, appearing in the narrator's hotel room, explains that they are not two men. The retrospective montage reconfigures the past, and the film's earlier subliminal insertions of Tyler,

single frames cut into scenes before his formal introduction, are revealed as the medium's own foreknowledge: the film had a double before its protagonist did.

The chemical model proposes that the revelation be read as a molecule recognizing its structure. The soap molecule is amphiphilic, a hydrophilic head and a lipophilic tail joined in one body. The narrator is the hydrophilic end, the end that seeks the medium of others, weeps, joins groups, and cannot sleep without a breast to cry against. Tyler is the lipophilic end, the end with an affinity for fat, grease, engines, and blows. Neither end exists apart from the other, and the molecule's power lies in binding what neither end could bind alone. The question the revelation poses is therefore not which end to amputate, a question the final shot answers only partially and at great cost, but what the molecule will bind. Aggregated with others of its kind, it forms micelles, and Chapter Four follows that aggregation. Bound to a substance it cannot cleave, it forms an emulsion, and Chapter Seven follows that binding.









04

CHAPTER FOUR

Glycerol

Project Mayhem and the Economy of Catastrophic Expenditure

STAGE 04 / PRODUCT / GLYCEROL

When the bonds that hold the narrator's thymos to his consumer identity are cleaved, the liberated core does not become freedom; it becomes glycerol, sweet, volatile, and awaiting nitration.

4.1 From Micelle to Mesophase

Fight club begins in the basement of Lou's Tavern under eight rules, the first two of which are identical: one does not talk about fight club. Its members return to their offices bruised and swollen, and no one asks. Palahniuk has traced the novel's origin to precisely this silence: beaten on a camping trip after complaining about a neighbouring group's radio, he returned to work bruised and swollen and found that colleagues avoided asking what had happened. He concluded that if you looked bad enough, people would not want to know what you did in your spare time.

The micelle is the exact form of this social arrangement. Above a critical concentration, amphiphiles in water assemble into spheres whose lipophilic tails cluster inward, sequestered from the medium, while their hydrophilic heads face outward, compatible with it. The fight circle is a ring of men around a violent core; toward the office and the street each presents the compliant surface of the employee; the rule of silence is the sequestration that keeps the core from the medium. And the micelle is how soap cleans: it encloses the grease that water cannot dissolve and allows it to be rinsed away. Fight club encloses the undischargeable aggression of the restricted economy and renders it invisible. Its men return to work calmer; afterwards, the narrator reports, the volume of everything else is turned down. In Herbert Marcuse's term from *One-Dimensional Man* (1964), fight club is an apparatus of *repressive desublimation*, a controlled release of drive that strengthens the order it appears to defy. It is a social detergent.

The critical micelle concentration names what happens next. As fight clubs multiply across American cities, many founded without the narrator's knowledge, the concentration of the amphiphile in the social medium crosses a threshold, and the micelles order themselves into a mesophase: Project Mayhem, with committees, homework, uniforms, a barracks, and a chain of command. The chemistry offers what moral accounts of radicalization lack, a model in which the passage from therapeutic secrecy to organized militancy is willed by no participant but follows from density. Once enough men inhabit micelles, the system crystallizes. The pertinence of the model to the online subcultures that later adopted the text's iconography, in which isolated grievance acquires structure once the aggrieved reach sufficient concentration, needs no emphasis.

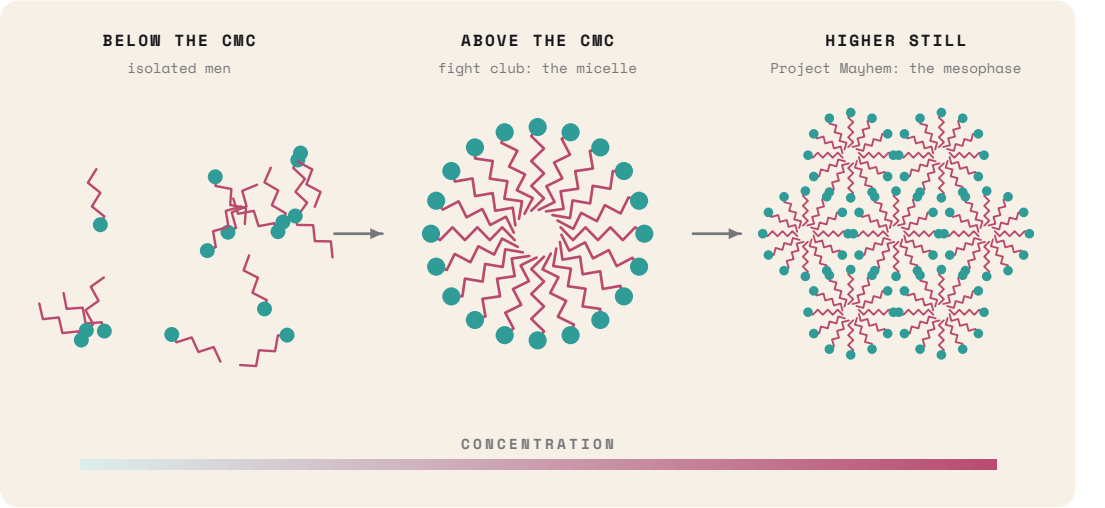


FIG. 7 FROM MICELLE TO MESOPHASE

Radicalization as a function of density: isolated men, the micelle of fight club, the ordered mesophase of Project Mayhem.

4.2 Expenditure, Potlatch, Acéphale

Bataille's "The Notion of Expenditure" (1933) catalogued the forms of unproductive expenditure, among them luxury, mourning, war, cults, monuments, games, spectacles, and perverse sexuality, and argued that societies are defined less by how they produce than by how they spend. Bourgeois society, having privatized and shamed expenditure, condemns its surplus to catastrophic forms. Marcel Mauss's *Essay on the Gift* (1925) had described the potlatch of the Pacific Northwest, in which chiefs gave away or destroyed wealth, breaking engraved coppers and burning goods, to establish rank: destruction as a technique of recognition. Project Mayhem's acts form a negative potlatch: a corporate sculpture, a great metal sphere, sent rolling into a franchise coffee bar; franchise property defaced; financial towers prepared for demolition. It is a potlatch addressed to no rival chief but to the system itself, seeking rank through destruction without the return gift that, for Mauss, bound the potlatch into a social order.

The intellectual history has a single room at its centre. The lectures on Hegel that Kojève delivered at the École Pratique des Hautes Études between 1933 and 1939 were attended by Bataille, Lacan, Queneau (who later edited them), Merleau-Ponty, Aron, and Klossowski, among others; recognition, expenditure, and desire as the desire of the Other share an origin in that seminar. Bataille drew from it an experiment that is Project Mayhem's most exact precursor. *Acéphale*, the review he founded in 1936 under André Masson's emblem of a headless man, was doubled by a secret society of the same name whose members were bound to silence about its rites and, by later accounts, met at night in the forest of Marly beside an oak struck by lightning, a site discussed in Marina Galletti's history of the society (2018). According to testimony that

has passed into the legend of the period, the society contemplated a human sacrifice as its founding act and found volunteers for the role of victim but no one willing to wield the knife; Masson, keeping his vow of silence, later suggested that an animal was to have stood in for the human victim. Alongside it, the College of Sociology (1937–39) of Bataille, Roger Caillois, and Michel Leiris pursued a "sacred sociology" of secret societies and festivals; Caillois's manifesto "The Winter Wind," published with the College's founding texts in July 1938, called for a hard, closed order of the spiritually elect (an elitism that René Bertelé, reviewing it that year in the journal Europe, likened to Nazi theories of selection), and his *Man and the Sacred* (1939) described the festival as a paroxysm of expenditure whose modern successor is war. Walter Benjamin is reported to have called the fascination of Bataille's circle with sacrifice a "pre-fascist aestheticism." Project Mayhem is Acéphale with an executioner.

> ***Project Mayhem is Acéphale with an executioner.***

It is also Acéphale with a head, though a split one. The movement's founder does not know that he founded it; its head is a dissociated portion of a body that believes itself a follower, so that acephaly becomes dissociation. The narrator's final act, a shot fired through his own head that kills the movement's leader, completes the acephalic sacrament: he decapitates Project Mayhem by passing a bullet through the skull he shares with it.

4.3 The Rule, the Novitiate, and the Corpse

The organization of Project Mayhem is monastic, and its sources are more exact than its critics have recognized. Chapter 58 of the Rule of Saint Benedict (c. 530) directs that a newcomer not be granted easy entrance: only if he perseveres in knocking and is seen, after four or five days, to bear patiently the injuries offered him and the difficulty of admission is he to be received. The applicant on Tyler's porch, insulted for three days as too old, too fat, or too blond, undergoes the Benedictine trial as exactly as the Zen *niwa-zume* discussed in Chapter Two. He arrives bringing black clothing, black boots, and three hundred dollars for his own burial: the postulant's habit and the funerary provision, a monk already provisioned for his death. The shaved heads are a tonsure, the uniforms a habit, the house on Paper Street a dormitory, the rules a *regula* that prizes silence and obedience. The Constitutions of the Society of Jesus ask the obedient to submit *perinde ac si cadaver essent*, as though they were corpses; the space monkey's obedience is cadaveric in exactly that sense.

Klaus Theweleit's *Male Fantasies* (1977–78), a study of the writings of Freikorps veterans, the paramilitary volunteers who fought the German left after 1918 and from whose ranks many

Nazis came, describes the soldier male who builds a body-armour of discipline against the threat of dissolution, imagined as flood, as the masses, and above all as the feminine, figured as fluid. The space monkeys are armoured in this sense: dry, hard, interchangeable. The chemistry concurs. Soaps made with sodium hydroxide are hard and are pressed into bars; soaps made with potassium hydroxide are soft. Tyler's lye yields hard soap. The narrator's tears and Bob's breasts belong to the soft and the fluid, which the discipline of Project Mayhem exists to expel.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovered from archaic Roman law the figure who may be killed but not sacrificed, the bearer of bare life. The space monkey, named, as the narrator explains, after the animals shot into space to die for a purpose they could not comprehend, is bare life as volunteer. Bob's death exposes the mechanism. Shot in the head by police during a mission, his body is carried back to the house, where the space monkeys propose to bury it in the garden to destroy the evidence. The narrator protests that Bob was a person with a name, and the space monkeys convert the protest into liturgy: in death a member of Project Mayhem has a name, and "His name is Robert Paulson" becomes the movement's litany. The man merely killed is converted by the chant into a sacrifice, and the name is the sacrificial supplement.

Hegel's reading of Sophocles in Chapter VI of the *Phenomenology* opposes the divine law of the family, which honours the singular dead with burial, to the human law of the city, which subordinates the individual to the universal. Insisting on Bob's singular name, the narrator occupies Antigone's position; Project Mayhem occupies Creon's. But the text adds a turn that neither Sophocles nor Hegel foresaw: Creon co-opts Antigone's claim, restoring the name only to universalize it in the mouths of men who have none of their own. The *Catechism of a Revolutionary* (1869), written in Geneva and usually attributed to Sergei Nechayev, though Bakunin's share in it is still debated, had stated the condition in its first article: the revolutionary is a doomed man, with no interests of his own, no affairs, no feelings, no attachments, no property, and "ни даже имени," not even a name. Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1871–72), written in response to the murder of the student Ivanov by Nechayev's circle, shows Pyotr Verkhovensky binding his cell through complicity in the murder of Shatov, while Shigalyov confesses that, starting from unlimited freedom, he arrives at unlimited despotism, and Kirillov kills himself to prove that self-will can make a man a god. Tyler is Verkhovensky's method joined to Stavrogin's charisma, and the passage from fight club to Project Mayhem is Shigalyovism enacted. The narrator's final act inverts Kirillov's: Kirillov shoots himself to become a god; the narrator shoots himself to unmake one.

4.4 The Fetish of the Age

In Conrad's *The Secret Agent* (1907), the embassy official Mr Vladimir instructs his agent that an outrage, to be effective, must strike the sacrosanct fetish of the age, which is no longer royalty or religion but science, and proposes the Greenwich Observatory: "The blowing up of the first

meridian is bound to raise a howl of execration." The target is chosen for an audience whose sensibilities, Vladimir explains, are jaded: only an outrage of apparently senseless ferocity will reach them. Project Mayhem addresses the same audience. Conrad's novel transfigures the death of the anarchist Martial Bourdin, killed by his own bomb in Greenwich Park in 1894, and surrounds its plot with the Professor, who walks London carrying a detonator, and with Stevie, the innocent destroyed by the device he carries. The doctrine of propaganda by the deed, articulated by Paul Brousse in 1877, and the sentence that closes Bakunin's essay of 1842, "Die Lust der Zerstörung ist zugleich eine schaffende Lust," the passion for destruction is at the same time a creative passion, supply the theory Tyler vulgarizes. Bakunin wrote as a Left Hegelian who had made the negative itself the creative motor of the dialectic, and Tyler's lye descends from that inversion of Hegel.

The targets of *Fight Club* vary between versions in a way that confirms Conrad's insight. The novel's Project Mayhem intends to topple the Parker-Morris Building onto a national museum: the fetish of the age as history. The film's Project Mayhem demolishes the headquarters of credit-card companies: the fetish of the age as debt. Greenwich, the museum, and the credit bureau are all archives of zero-points, the places from which time, the past, and obligation are counted. Tyler's promise that erasing the debt record will return everyone to zero is a promise to blow up the meridian of value.

Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) argued that the Freudian death drive is anarchivic, or archiviolithic: it works to destroy the archive and to efface even its own traces. Project Mayhem is archiviolithic in both directions. Outwardly it destroys the record of debt; inwardly, through the narrator's amnesia, it destroys the record of its own founding, so that the one who acts as Tyler leaves no trace in the one who remembers. Baudrillard's *The Spirit of Terrorism* (2002) argued that the attacks of 11 September 2001, in which nineteen al-Qaeda hijackers flew airliners into the World Trade Center and the Pentagon and a fourth airliner crashed in Pennsylvania, killing nearly three thousand people, realized a fantasy the system had itself harboured: the hijackers acted, but the West had wished it. The final image of Fincher's film, made two years earlier, became after 2001 at once unwatchable as fantasy and unignorable as prophecy, and Žižek's *Welcome to the Desert of the Real* (2002) made the return of Hollywood's catastrophe-fantasies in reality a theme of the post-2001 conjuncture.

Per Serritslev Petersen (2005) has read *Fight Club* together with Bret Easton Ellis's *Glamorama* (1998) as "terrorist pretexts" of the attacks, novels that had imagined them in advance. The saponific reading specifies what such pre-imaginings share: they picture the catastrophe as the glycerol of an affluent order, the explosive residue of its own surplus, and so render it at once unthinkable as policy and familiar as fantasy.

4.5 Waldgang

Tyler's vision of the world after Project Mayhem is pastoral. He imagines men stalking elk through canyon forests grown up around the ruins of Rockefeller Center, dressed in leather that will last their lifetimes, climbing vines that have overgrown the Sears Tower, and drying venison on an abandoned highway. The vision has a literary ancestry in Richard Jefferies's *After London* (1885), whose England has relapsed into forest and feudal tribes around the poisonous swamp where London stood, in George R. Stewart's *Earth Abides* (1949), and in Thoreau's declaration in "Walking" (1862) that "in Wildness is the preservation of the World." It has a political ancestry as well. John Zerzan's anarcho-primitivism (*Future Primitive*, 1994) and the manifesto *Industrial Society and Its Future* framed modern malaise in terms *Fight Club* dramatizes. The manifesto's author, Theodore Kaczynski, had between 1978 and 1995 killed three people and injured twenty-three others with mail and package bombs; still unidentified, he offered to end the campaign if a major newspaper printed his text, and the *Washington Post* published it in September 1995 in an arrangement with the *New York Times*. Kaczynski's account of the "power process" (goal, effort, attainment, autonomy) and of the "surrogate activities" with which oversocialized moderns fill its absence describes fight club exactly: it is the surrogate activity par excellence, and Project Mayhem is the attempt to restore the power process through terror. That the manifesto was written to justify a campaign of murder is the reason it belongs in this genealogy, not an objection to placing it there.

The conjuncture matters. The novel was written and published in the years of three events that galvanized an armed American militia movement: the standoff at Ruby Ridge, Idaho (1992), in which a deputy US marshal and the separatist Randy Weaver's wife and teenage son were killed; the siege of the Branch Davidian compound near Waco, Texas (1993), which began with a raid in which four federal agents and six members of the sect died and ended in a fire that killed some seventy-six people, among them the group's leader, David Koresh, and more than twenty children; and the Oklahoma City bombing (1995), in which Timothy McVeigh, with the help of Terry Nichols, destroyed much of the Alfred P. Murrah Federal Building with a truck bomb, killing 168 people, nineteen of them children, on the second anniversary of the fire at Waco. Kaczynski was arrested in April 1996, the year the novel appeared. The film was released six months after the Columbine massacre, in which two students, Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold, killed twelve students and a teacher at their high school before killing themselves, and its release, originally planned for July, was pushed back to October, a delay widely attributed to the shooting. The pastoral apocalypse belongs to an American imaginary of masculine regeneration through violence whose history Richard Slotkin traced in *Regeneration Through Violence* (1973). Its mythic form is older still. In the *Völuspá*, after Ragnarök, the earth rises again from the sea, evergreen, and unsown fields bear grain. Tyler's elk inhabit the green world after the twilight of the gods: amargi as the return to Mother Earth.

4.6 The Sweet Principle

Glycerol entered chemistry as sweetness. Scheele isolated it in 1779 while heating olive oil with litharge and called it the sweet principle of fats. In 1847 Ascanio Sobrero prepared from it nitroglycerin, which he called pyroglycerine, and was so alarmed by its violence that he warned against its use; Alfred Nobel stabilized it as dynamite, patented in 1867, and willed the resulting fortune to a set of prizes, among them one for peace. The probably apocryphal premature obituary said to have called him a merchant of death, and so to have prompted the will, survives because it tells the truth about glycerol: the sweet principle passes through explosion into honour. Sweetness, detonation, and prize are the three moments of thymos in chemical form, the jouissance hidden in accumulated fat, the catastrophic expenditure, and the recognition, and *Fight Club* contains all three: the euphoria of the fights and of Raymond's promised breakfast, the bombs, and the name conferred in death.

The novel diverges from the film at the last moment. Its climax turns on a failed mixture, so that the bomb in the Parker-Morris Building does not detonate. The divergence can now be stated chemically: the novel arrests the reaction before the glycerol is spent; the film runs it to completion. That the Chinese censors of 2022 chose the novel's arrest over the film's completion is a fact about the political chemistry of the text to which Chapter Seven returns.



05

CHAPTER FIVE

Mythography of the Rendered

STAGE 05 / MATRIX / MYTH

Beneath its contemporary surfaces, *Fight Club* re-enacts a small number of very old stories: the division of sacrificial substance, the making of a double, the coming of a stranger-god, and the exchange of a wound for a name. The oldest and most exact is Hesiod's account of Prometheus at Mecone.

5.1 Mecone: Prometheus and the Division of Fat

In Hesiod's *Theogony* (535–616), gods and mortals are being separated at Mecone when Prometheus divides a great ox. In one portion he hides the meat and rich entrails inside the ox's stomach, unappetizing without and nourishing within; in the other he arranges the bare white bones with crafty art and covers them with gleaming fat, beautiful without and worthless within. Zeus chooses the fat-covered bones, knowingly, Hesiod insists, and from that day mortals burn white bones wrapped in fat for the gods. In anger Zeus withholds fire; Prometheus steals it in a hollow fennel stalk; and Zeus answers with the first woman, a "beautiful evil" fashioned by Hephaestus, from whom descend the women Hesiod compares to drones that sit in the hive consuming the labour of the bees. Jean-Pierre Vernant's analysis of the episode, in the volume he edited with Marcel Detienne (1979), showed that the Promethean sacrifice founds the human condition: separation from the gods, mortality, the necessity of labour, the use of fire, and marriage.

Fight Club re-enacts Mecone with startling fidelity. Its first act is a division of fat by deception: Tyler packages the surplus fat of the wealthy as luxury soap and sells it back to them, so that the rich receive their own fat beautifully wrapped while the renderers keep the substance, the money and, in the end, the glycerol. Its second is the theft of fire: lye, the fire without flame that Barthes heard in the advertising of caustic cleansers, and then the explosive. Its third is the arrival of woman experienced as punishment. The narrator says that if he had a tumour he would name it Marla, and Tyler's sermon on "a generation of men raised by women" reproduces Hesiod's drone: woman as consumer of male surplus, the rich women who buy the soap, the woman who ends the narrator's peace. The three founding acts of the Promethean condition, the sacrifice of fat, the theft of fire, and the coming of woman, are the three movements of the plot.

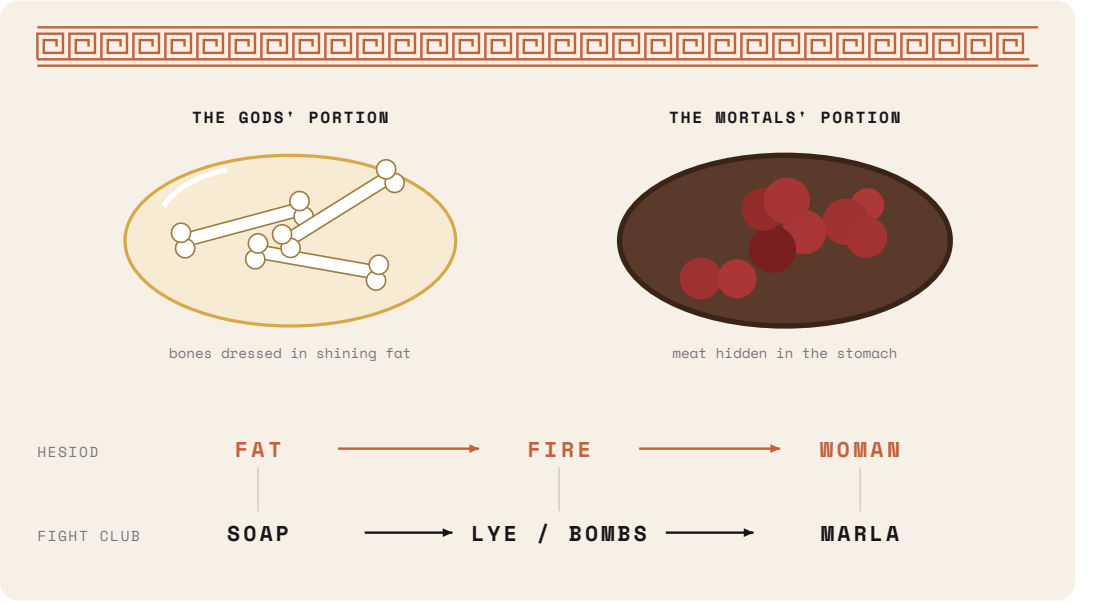


FIG. 8 THE DIVISION AT MECONE

Prometheus divides the ox. The three founding acts of the human condition return as the three movements of the plot.

The punishment confirms the pattern. Bound to a pillar, Prometheus has his liver devoured each day by an eagle and regrown each night (*Theogony* 521–525): the endless rendering of the organ of fat. Among the organs that narrate their lives in the film's parody of the *Reader's Digest* series is the narrator's "raging bile duct," the liver's channel. Aeschylus's *Prometheus Bound* made the Titan the defiant benefactor of humankind, punished for a gift, and so supplied the template of the rebel whose suffering certifies his cause, one Tyler claims when he teaches that pain and loss are the price of freedom. Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818) made the Promethean creature the double of its creator, abandoned by an absent father and demanding the recognition he was denied. On the glacier at Montanvert the creature tells Victor, "I ought to be thy Adam; but I am rather the fallen angel," and then, "I was benevolent and good; misery made me a fiend." Tyler's theology of the father who never wanted his sons is that grievance generalized to a generation: God's unwanted children are Adams who have become fallen angels.

5.2 Enkidu: The Wild Double Made of Clay

In the Standard Babylonian *Epic of Gilgamesh*, attributed to Sîn-lēqi-unninni, the people of Uruk complain of their king's oppression, and the goddess Aruru pinches off clay and creates Enkidu, a wild man living among the animals, to be Gilgamesh's equal and a match for his restless heart. Humanized by the courtesan Shamhat, Enkidu blocks Gilgamesh's path at the door of the house

where he would claim the bride; they wrestle, and from the fight comes an inseparable friendship. Enkidu's death teaches Gilgamesh that he too will die; his quest for immortality fails when a serpent steals the plant of rejuvenation; and the epic ends, as it began, on the walls of Uruk, the durable work of civilization.

The parking-lot fight is the wrestling at the door, and the friendship born of combat is Gilgamesh's. But every term is inverted. Enkidu is made by the gods to check a tyrant; Tyler is made by a powerless man in order to become one. Shamhat civilizes the wild man through sex; Marla's affair with Tyler provokes the tame man's wildness. Enkidu's death teaches mortality; Tyler teaches mortality from the beginning, and his death teaches the narrator instead the possibility of survival. And where the epic returns to the walls, *Fight Club* ends at a window, watching towers fall.

5.3 Iron Hans in the Basement

The tale the Brothers Grimm published as "Der Eisenhans" (KHM 136) finds a wild man, rust-coloured and hairy, at the bottom of a forest pool and cages him in the king's courtyard. The prince's golden ball rolls into the cage; the wild man will return it only if the boy frees him; the key lies under the queen's pillow; the boy steals it and is carried into the forest. Set to guard a golden spring, he lets first his finger and then his hair touch the water, and both turn gold. Sent into the world, he hides his hair beneath a cap and works as kitchen boy and gardener's boy at a foreign court; in war he rides anonymously with Iron Hans's help and wins; at a festival he catches the princess's golden apple on three successive days in three suits of armour, is wounded in the leg, and is recognized. At his wedding Iron Hans appears as a king released from enchantment.

Robert Bly's *Iron John* made the tale the founding text of the mythopoetic men's movement, reading the key under the mother's pillow as the necessity of stealing masculine energy from maternal custody. *Fight Club*'s first act ridicules that movement in Remaining Men Together; its second performs the myth. Thoreau had given the tale an American accent in "Walking" (1862): "Give me for my friends and neighbors wild men, not tame ones." The film grants the wish. Tyler is the wild man who lives below, in the basement; he is released when the narrator's maternal nest explodes; the members of Project Mayhem are princes disguised in service, waiters, cooks, and projectionists whose golden hair is hidden under the uniform's cap; their anonymous feats are the incognito knight's; the wound is the burn. The film mocks the mythopoetic in the register of therapy and then enacts it in the register of terror. Satire and object exchange places, and the exchange is itself a saponification: the soft, therapeutic form of the myth is cleaved, and its hard, militant form precipitates.

5.4 The Stranger-God

Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE) brings Dionysus to Thebes disguised as a long-haired Lydian stranger whose beauty the young king Pentheus finds effeminate. Pentheus imprisons him; in the "palace miracle" the earth shakes, fire flares on Semele's tomb, and the royal house is wrecked. Dionysus then seduces Pentheus, who longs to see the women's rites, into dressing as a maenad and spying from a tree on Cithaeron, where his mother Agave and the women tear him apart; she carries his head home believing it a lion's until her father brings her to recognition.

The mapping is close. The orderly young man who denies the god is the narrator of the catalogue, Apollonian in Nietzsche's sense, devoted to measure and to the dream of a coherent self; the stranger is Tyler, beautiful and foreign to that order. The destruction of the house is the explosion of the condominium; the voyeurism is the narrator listening to Tyler and Marla through the wall; the dismembering mother is the fantasy of maternal violence that underwrites Tyler's misogyny; the head carried home is the narrator's own, and Agave's recognition is his. Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) read the Dionysian as the shattering of the *principium individuationis*; the fights are Dionysian in exactly this sense, and the narrator reports that afterwards nothing was solved but nothing mattered. Walter F. Otto (1933) called Dionysus the god who comes, and Girard read Pentheus and Dionysus as monstrous doubles. *Fight Club* departs from Euripides at the decisive point. Its Pentheus is not torn apart by the women: he turns the violence upon himself in a measured dose and takes a woman's hand. The self-wound replaces the *sparagmos*.

> ***The self-wound replaces the sparagmos.***

5.5 Jacob, Outis, and the Economy of the Name

At the ford of the Jabbok (Genesis 32:22–32), Jacob wrestles through the night with a stranger who, unable to prevail, strikes the socket of his hip; Jacob demands a blessing and is renamed Israel, but when he asks the stranger's name he is refused. Barthes's structural analysis of the passage (1971) emphasized its undecidabilities and the exchange at its centre: a mark on the body in return for a name. The narrator wrestles with a stranger at night, is marked, and receives no name. More precisely, he discovers that the stranger's name is his own, so that the wound purchases not a new identity but the loss of the borrowed ones. Even "Jack" was never a name but a possessive, the owner of the medulla oblongata and the bile duct in the organ-autobiographies he reads in the house on Paper Street.

Homer supplies the counter-scene. In the ninth book of the *Odyssey*, Odysseus tells the Cyclops that his name is *Outis*, Nobody, and later, at sea, boasts his true name and incurs Poseidon's curse. Horkheimer and Adorno read the Nobody trick as the prototype of the bourgeois subject, who preserves himself by denying himself. The narrator is Outis by profession: he survives as no one. In the text's economy, names belong to the dead and to the state. Bob receives his name in death; Raymond K. Hessel's name is printed on a licence that Tyler keeps as collateral, the name held as the creditor holds the debtor's bond.

5.6 Gnosis, Golem, Ragnarök

The Gnostic *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the *Acts of Thomas*, tells of a prince sent into Egypt to retrieve a pearl guarded by a serpent, who forgets his origin and sinks into sleep until a letter, flying to him as an eagle, wakes him; returning with the pearl, he receives his robe and sees himself in it as in a mirror, two in distinction and one in form. The insomniac who sleeps while seeming to wake, roused by a stranger who proves to be his own image, is the prince of the *Hymn*, and the Gospel of Thomas (logion 22) promises the kingdom to those who make the two into one. Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958), in the essay on Gnosticism, existentialism, and nihilism that became its epilogue, argued that the Gnostic experience of a hostile cosmos and an alien God anticipated modern nihilism. Tyler's theology is Gnostic: the father-creator is a Demiurge who does not love his creatures, the archons are the powers of consumption and credit, and the stranger's call awakens the spark. Dick named the prison the Black Iron Prison; the Wachowskis' *The Matrix*, released seven months before *Fight Club*, gave 1999 its other Gnostic myth.

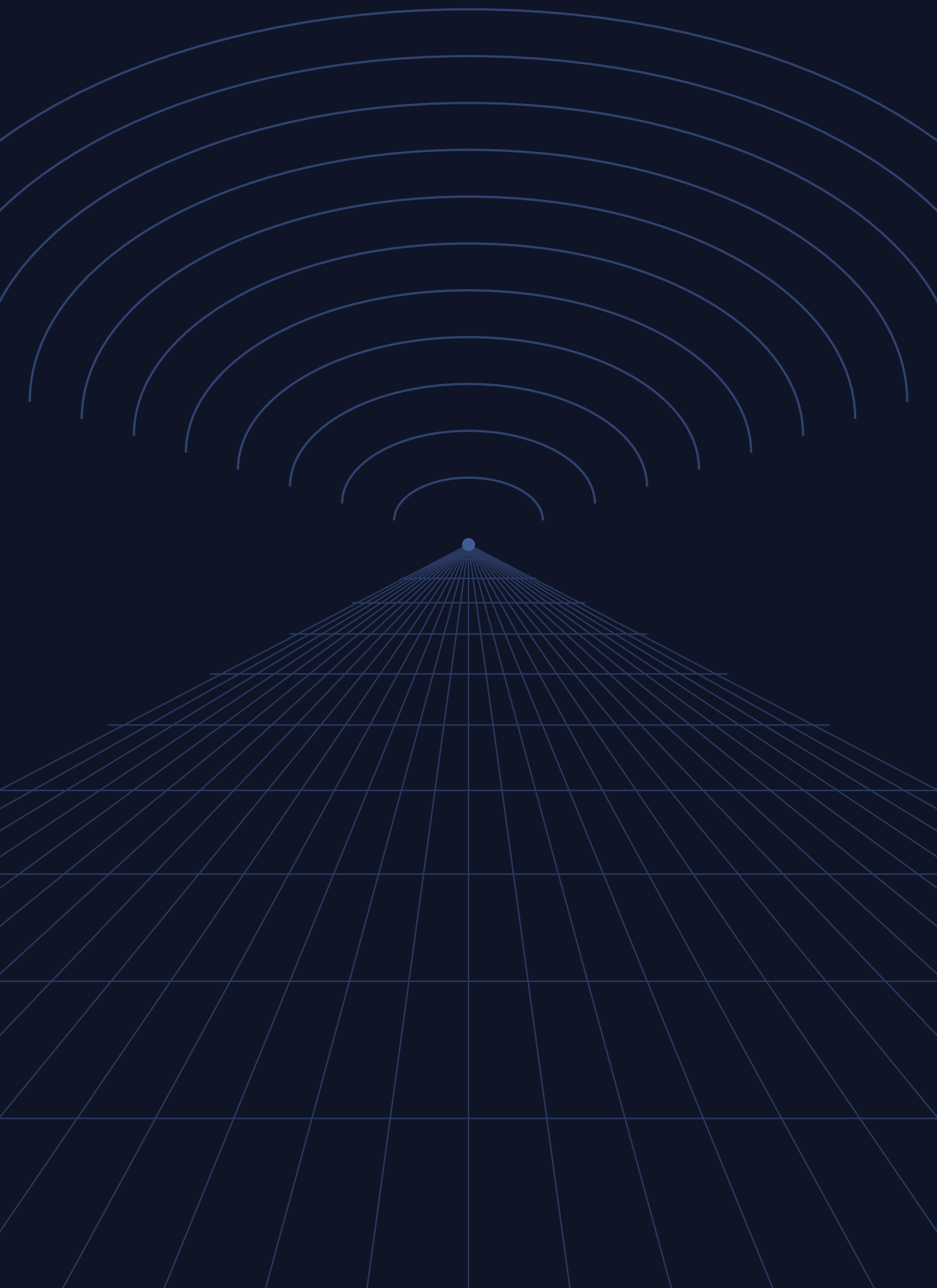
The Golem of Prague is animated by *emet*, truth, inscribed on its forehead, and destroyed when the first letter is erased, leaving *met*, dead. The narrator unmakes Tyler by an act of truth, but the truth must be inscribed where the Golem's word was written: the head. Norse eschatology supplies the end. Bound beneath a serpent whose venom drips on his face, Loki convulses whenever his wife Sigyn empties the bowl in which she catches it, and the earth shakes; at Ragnarök he breaks free, the gods fall, and the world burns, until the earth rises again, green, from the sea. Tyler is Loki: the trickster who brings the end, the caustic on the flesh, and, beyond the burning, the green world of the elk.

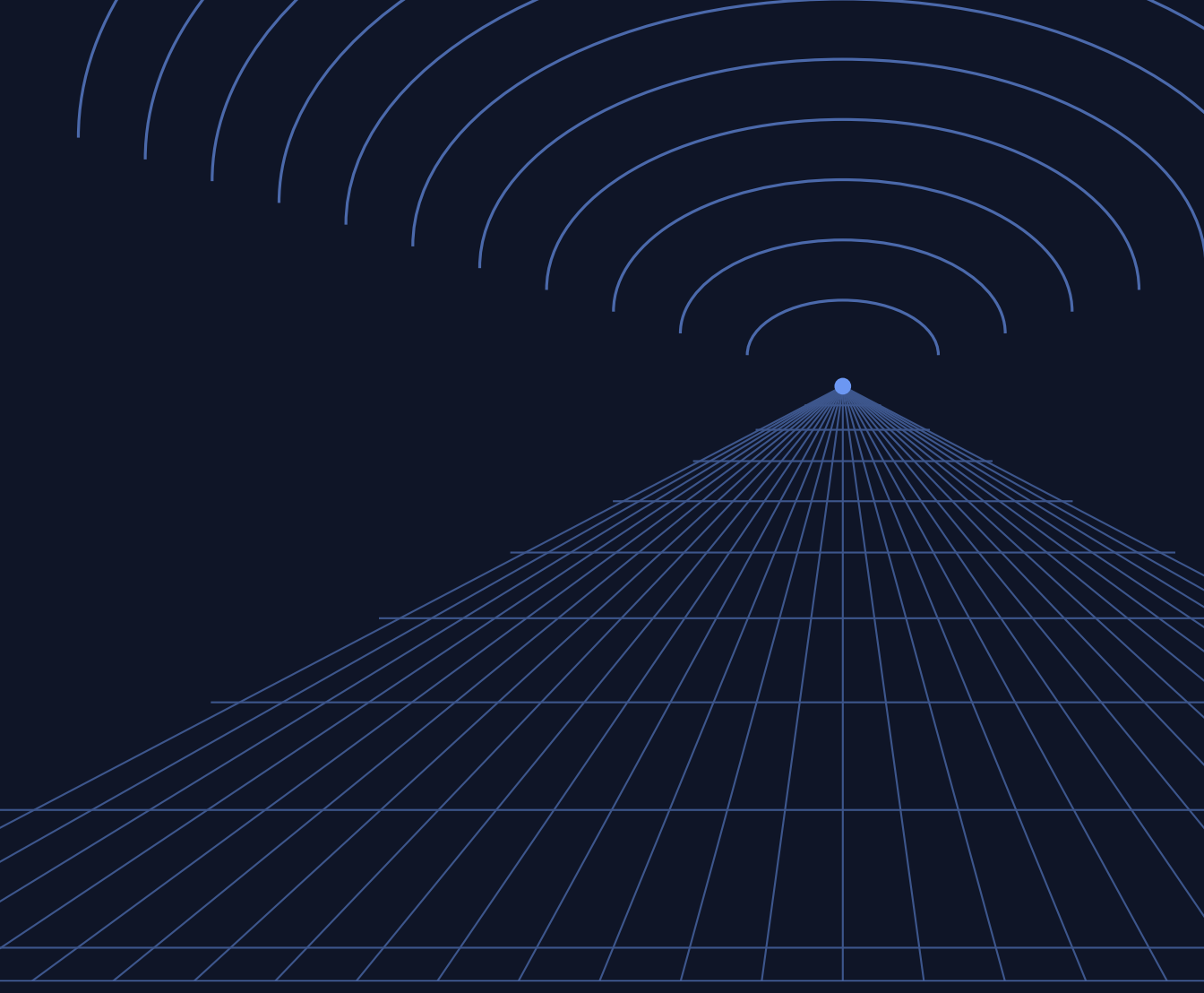
5.7 The Pharmacy and the Apostle

In Plato's *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), Theuth offers writing to King Thamus as a *pharmakon* for memory, and Thamus replies that it will produce forgetfulness. Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) unfolded the undecidability of *pharmakon*, remedy and poison at once, and traced its kinship with *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city. *Fight Club* is organized as a pharmacy.

The physician withholds the sleeping pills; the support groups become the remedy, and Marla poisons them; pain becomes the next remedy; soap, the remedy for dirt, is made from what is abject, and its by-product is the poison; Marla's overdose of Xanax, a sedative of the kind the physician refused the narrator, is the withheld pharmakon returning as poison, turned against the self; and the double is expelled at last as *pharmakos*. The narrator's amnesia fulfils Thamus's prophecy.

Tyler is also Socrates: the gadfly of the *Apology* who stings the city awake and is accused of corrupting its youth, whose interrogation of Raymond K. Hessel about the life he wished to lead is the elenchus at gunpoint. Socrates' *daimonion*, the inner voice he describes in the *Apology*, only ever held him back from action; Tyler is a *daimonion* that only urges it. Socrates' last words in the *Phaedo* concern a debt, a cock owed to Asclepius, which Nietzsche read as a confession that life is a long sickness. *Fight Club* inverts the last word: instead of paying the debt to the healer, its climax abolishes debt as such. Palahniuk has described the novel as an update of *The Great Gatsby*, "apostolic" fiction in which a surviving apostle tells the story of his hero: two men and a woman, and the hero shot to death. Suzanne del Gizzo has read the two novels together as versions of the American Dream unhinged (2007). The apostolic form runs from Plato and the evangelists through Ishmael and Ahab, Marlow and Kurtz, and Nick Carraway and Gatsby, to Chief Bromden and McMurphy. *Fight Club* folds it into itself: apostle and hero are one person, so that narrating the master's death is killing him. In the *Sophist* (241d) the Eleatic Stranger begs not to be taken for a parricide as he lays hands on the doctrine of his father Parmenides, which he must test and partly overturn to show that not-being, in a sense, is. Writing his memoir of Tyler, the narrator performs the parricide the Stranger disavowed: he is the apostle who kills his Socrates in order to speak.





06

CHAPTER SIX

Speculative Comparanda

Dystopia, Simulation, and the Therapeutic State

STAGE 06 / COMPARANDA

Read against the speculative tradition, *Fight Club* appears as a dystopia without a state: the World State, the One State, and the Party have been replaced by the catalogue and the credit bureau, so that rebellion, having no sovereign to oppose, must invent one inside the rebel.

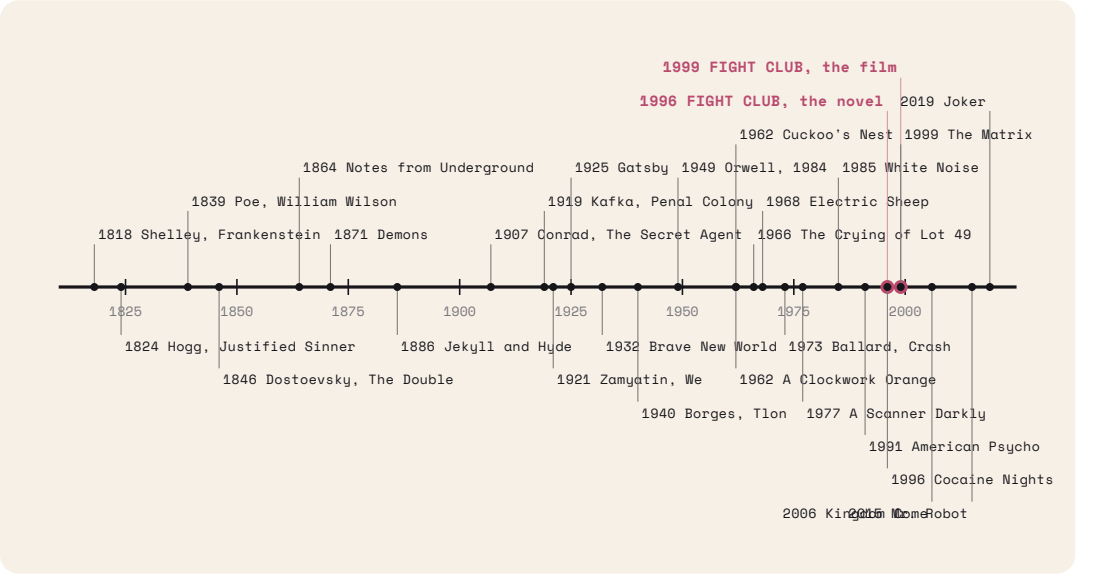


FIG. 9 A GENEALOGY IN TIME

Selected comparanda, 1818–2019. The novel (1996) and the film (1999) sit inside a dense late-century cluster.

6.1 The Right to Be Unhappy

Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) is the first great dystopia of consumption. Its citizens are conditioned in sleep to believe that ending is better than mending and that everyone belongs to everyone else; its games are licensed only if they require elaborate apparatus and so stimulate production; and its *soma* is the perfect pharmakon, offering, in the Controller's account, the advantages of religion and alcohol without their defects. John the Savage, raised on a reservation with a volume of Shakespeare, refuses the arrangement. Against the Controller, Mustapha Mond, he demands God, poetry, real danger, freedom, goodness, and sin, and when Mond observes that he is claiming the right to be unhappy, together with the right to grow old and ugly and to suffer, he accepts the description. He withdraws to a lighthouse and flagellates himself; sightseers arrive; a film is made of his penance; he hangs himself.

Fight Club is the right to be unhappy collectivized. The basement supplies what the World State forbids, and fight club's sport, which requires no equipment, no shirts, and no shoes, is the

antithesis of the World State's apparatus-hungry games. The narrator's self-beating in his superior's office is the Savage's flagellation, and it acquires, like the Savage's, an audience. Huxley foresaw what follows: the spectacle of self-punishment is filmed and sold. The fate of the Savage's penance is the fate of fight club, which becomes a franchise, and of *Fight Club*, which becomes a commodity.

6.2 The Crystal Palace and the Green Wall

The architectural genealogy of the narrator's condominium begins in Hyde Park in 1851, in Joseph Paxton's Crystal Palace, the first temple of world commodities. In *Notes from Underground* (1864), Dostoevsky's anti-hero refuses the Crystal Palace as the emblem of a rational utopia in which man would become a piano key; he insists that man may choose against his own interest merely to prove himself free, that two times two makes four is the beginning of death, and that suffering is the sole origin of consciousness. Peter Sloterdijk's *In the World Interior of Capital* (2005) took the Crystal Palace as the image of globalized capitalism as such, a climatized interior in which the comfortable live sheltered from history. The Underground Man is *Fight Club*'s first anti-hero, and IKEA is his Crystal Palace, furnished.

Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (1920–21) built the Crystal Palace into a city. In the One State, citizens live in glass houses under the Table of Hours and the Benefactor, and the engineer D-503 builds the *Integral*, a ship that will carry happiness to other planets. Seduced by I-330 into the conspiracy of the Mephi, who make contact with the hairy, wild humans beyond the Green Wall, he discovers with shame that his own hands are hairy, the atavism inside the engineer; the state answers the rebellion with the Great Operation, which removes the imagination. Benjamin, in "Experience and Poverty" (1933), saw in glass the enemy of secrets and of possession, the material on which nothing leaves a trace. The catalogue apartment, the glass house, and the Crystal Palace form one architecture of tracelessness. The Mephi are Tyler's elk-hunters; I-330 combines Marla's provocation with Tyler's charisma; and Tyler's announcement that his men are not beautiful and unique snowflakes is the Great Operation performed by the rebellion rather than the state. In George Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), the forbidden book of the opposition is written by the Party, and O'Brien teaches through pain that two and two make five. Dostoevsky's formula for freedom and Orwell's formula for submission are the same formula, and Tyler's pedagogy stands at their hinge: pain teaching a freedom that is obedience.

6.3 The Twenty-First Chapter

Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) narrates the crimes of Alex and his droogs (beatings, a home invasion in which a woman is raped, and the killing of a woman during a burglary, all of which the novel's slang calls ultraviolence), his imprisonment, and his subjection to the

Ludovico technique, an aversion therapy that renders him incapable of violence and, the prison chaplain objects, of moral choice: a man who cannot choose ceases to be a man. Burgess wrote twenty-one chapters; in the last, Alex, at eighteen, grows bored with violence and imagines a son. The American edition omitted the chapter until 1986, and Stanley Kubrick's film (1971) followed the American text, ending with Alex cured of his cure. The parallel with *Fight Club* is exact. In both, the version the culture remembers ends at the height of violence, while the version that ends in containment, Alex's maturity or the narrator's asylum, survives as a scholarly footnote; in both, the containment belongs to the novelist and the detonation to the film. Tyler's homework assignments are, moreover, a Ludovico technique in reverse, conditioning toward violence rather than away from it.

6.4 Mercer's Stones

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) imagines a religion, Mercerism, whose adherents grasp the handles of an empathy box and fuse with Wilbur Mercer, an old man climbing a hill while unseen assailants throw stones at him; the stones wound the believers, who bleed. A television personality exposes Mercer as a bit-part actor on a sound stage, but Mercer continues to appear to the faithful, and the exposure changes nothing. Fight club is Mercerism: communion through shared pain, real wounds inflicted under the sign of a figure who proves an illusion, and an illusion whose exposure does not abolish its efficacy. When the narrator learns that Tyler does not exist, Project Mayhem continues without interruption. Dick's doubles were examined in Chapter Three; *Electric Sheep* adds that a communal religion of suffering survives the death of its god.

6.5 Ballard's Therapeutic Violence

J. G. Ballard is *Fight Club*'s closest contemporary interlocutor, and the convergence, whatever its causes, is too exact to ignore. *Crash* (1973), narrated by a man named James Ballard, follows Vaughan, a charismatic prophet of the erotic car crash; the narrator of *Fight Club*, inspecting incinerated vehicles for his employer, works in Vaughan's landscape as its actuary. *Cocaine Nights* (1996), published the same year as Palahniuk's novel, describes a moribund community of affluent expatriates on the Costa del Sol revived by Bobby Crawford, a tennis professional who orchestrates burglary, arson, and worse, because crime is the only stimulus capable of generating community in a society without politics. *Super-Cannes* (2000) moves the thesis to a business park, Eden-Olympia, where the psychiatrist Wilder Penrose prescribes controlled violence to cure the malaise of executives: fight club as corporate wellness programme. *Millennium People* (2003) follows a middle-class revolt in a London estate led by Richard Gould, a paediatrician who holds that only a truly meaningless act can escape a world in which the market assigns

every act its meaning. *Kingdom Come* (2006) completes the sequence: in a shopping centre outside London, consumerism mutates into a fascist movement with sports-fan militias. Ballard's late quartet and Palahniuk's novel share a diagnosis: late-capitalist boredom requires violence, and consumerism is the soil of a new fascism. *Kingdom Come* is, in this dissertation's terms, the mesophase observed from inside the mall.

6.6 The Combine and the Big Nurse

Ken Kesey's *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest* (1962), another Oregon novel, is narrated by Chief Bromden, who perceives the hospital as a node of the Combine, a total system of adjustment that fills the ward with fog. Its charismatic hero, McMurphy, disrupts Nurse Ratched's group meetings, takes the men fishing, assaults Ratched, and is lobotomized; Bromden smothers the body and escapes, hurling the hydrotherapy console through the window. One patient, Harding, explains that the men are victims of a matriarchy. The parallels need little elaboration: the support groups are the group meetings, the matriarchy is the generation of men raised by women, McMurphy is Tyler, Bromden is the narrator, and in both novels the apostle kills the hero's husk in order to go free. The comparison also locates *Fight Club*'s gender politics in a lineage: the critique of the therapeutic state as castrating mother is Kesey's before it is Palahniuk's, and the feminist criticism of *Cuckoo's Nest* anticipated much of what has been said of *Fight Club*.

6.7 Brand, Supermarket, Trystero

Bret Easton Ellis's *American Psycho* (1991) is the consumer self without a double. Patrick Bateman catalogues his skin-care regimen and stereo equipment with the narrator's IKEA precision, competes with colleagues over the typography of their business cards in a scene of pure mimetic rivalry, commits murders whose reality the novel leaves undecidable, and confesses that there is no real him, only an entity. The novel ends on a sign: THIS IS NOT AN EXIT. *Fight Club* splits what *American Psycho* fuses, and the split is what preserves an exit: the narrator can reject Tyler because he is not entirely Tyler, whereas Bateman's catalogue and his murders speak in a single voice.

Don DeLillo's *White Noise* (1985) is narrated by Jack Gladney, a professor of Hitler studies who worships in the supermarket, fears death, and pursues Dylar, a drug designed to abolish the fear of death, the consumer pharmakon in its purest form. Gladney's colleague Murray theorizes that the killer gains life by killing; Gladney shoots the man who supplied his wife with the drug and is shot in turn. *Mao II* (1991) adds its novelist's claim that terrorists have taken over the novelist's power to shape the inner life of the culture, in a zero-sum game. *Fight Club* internalizes the game: the novelist-narrator and the terrorist are one man.

Thomas Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) sends Oedipa Maas in pursuit of the Trystero, a secret postal network of the disinherited that has run for centuries beneath official communication, its emblem a muted post horn, its acronym W.A.S.T.E. Pynchon leaves undecided whether the Trystero exists. Project Mayhem is a Trystero of the service class, lodged in the interstices of the official system: waiters, cooks, cleaners, projectionists, mechanics, and police. When its members seize the police commissioner who has vowed to shut the clubs down, pinning him in a hotel washroom during a banquet and threatening to castrate him unless he abandons the investigation, they remind him that the people he hunts are the people who prepare his food, collect his rubbish, and guard his sleep. *Fight Club* decides the question Pynchon left open: the network exists. What does not exist is its founder.

6.8 Borges and the Paper Street

Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) describes an imaginary world, invented by a secret society through an encyclopedia, that gradually displaces the real as its objects begin to appear in the world. Tyler's house stands on Paper Street, and the name is a term of art: a paper street exists on maps and plats but was never built. American cartography also knows the paper town, a fictitious place entered on a map to catch plagiarists; the most famous, Agloe, New York, invented by mapmakers in the 1930s, became real when a store was built at the empty crossroads and named after it. Tyler is a paper street that became a road, a fiction that acquires reality because people act as though it exists. In "The Circular Ruins" (1940), a man dreams another into being and discovers that he is himself dreamed; in "Three Versions of Judas" (1944), the theologian Nils Runeberg concludes that God became man not in Jesus but in Judas, assuming the most abject of destinies. Tyler, the redeemer through infamy who preaches to God's unwanted children, is Runeberg's Judas.

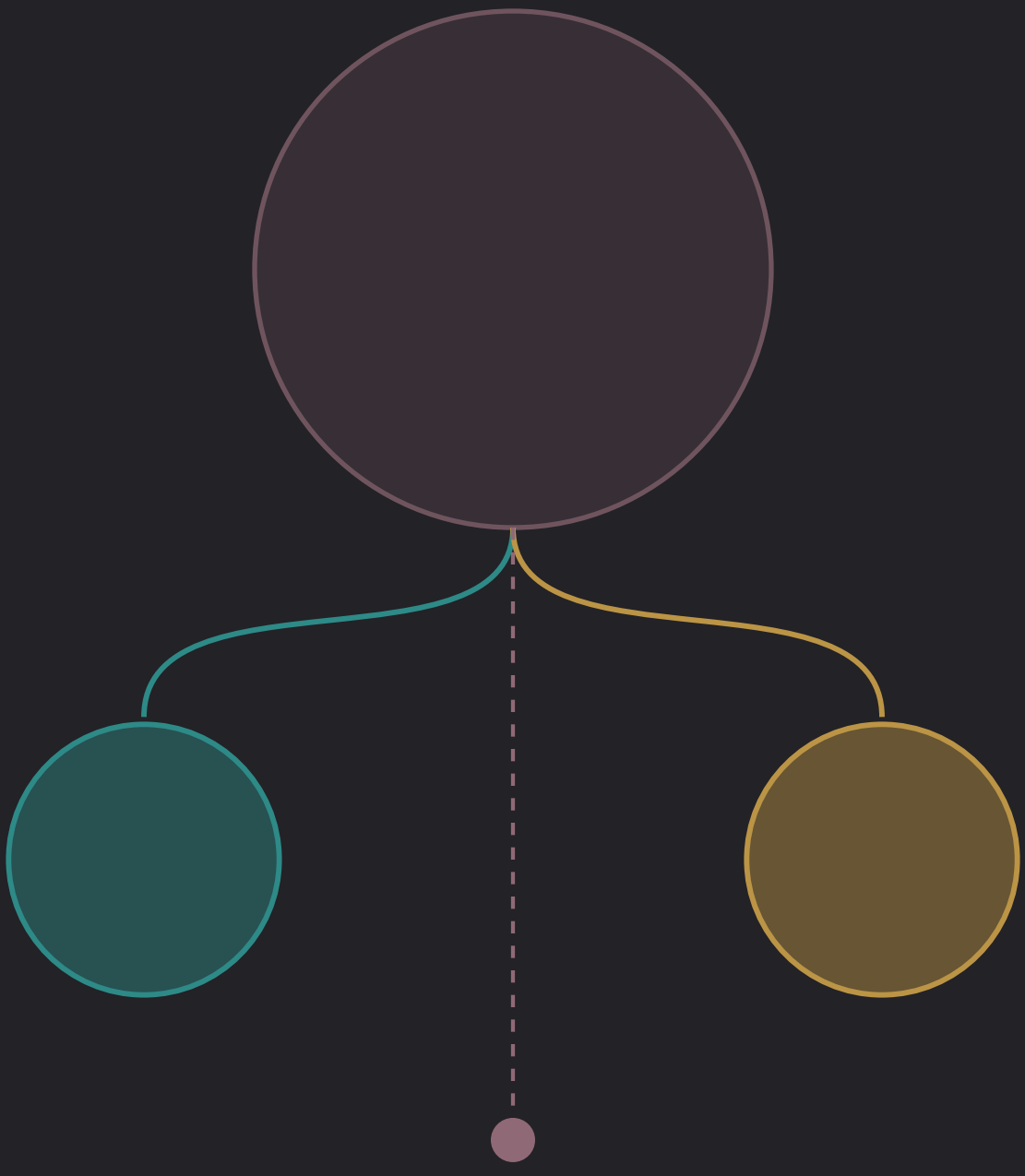
> ***Tyler is a paper street that became a road.***

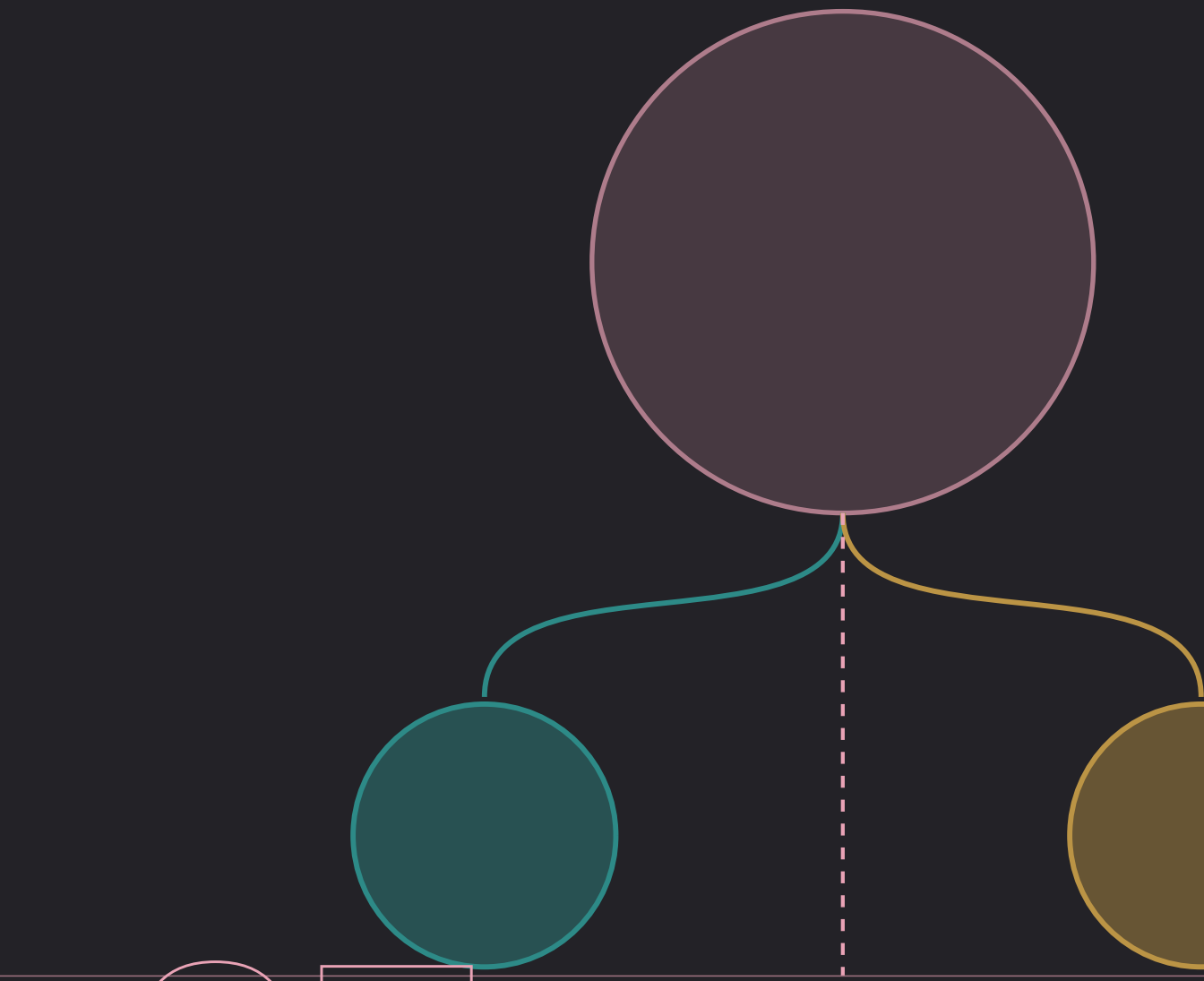
6.9 The 1999 Cluster and the Afterlife

Fight Club belongs to a remarkable concentration of American films released in 1999. In *The Matrix*, the programmer Thomas Anderson, a corporate employee by day and the hacker Neo by night, takes a pill that wakes him from a simulated world into the real one; a hollowed-out copy of Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* appears as a prop. In *American Beauty*, Lester Burnham, waking from what he calls a twenty-year coma, extorts a year's salary from his employer, takes a

job at a fast-food counter, lifts weights, and is shot. In *Office Space*, an interrupted hypnosis frees Peter Gibbons from his cubicle, and the company's building burns. In *Being John Malkovich*, identity becomes a portal through which others inhabit a head; in *The Sixth Sense*, a final revelation reconfigures everything the viewer has seen. Together they compose a millennial cinema of the cubicle uprising, in which the white-collar man wakes from simulated life through dissociation, violence, or death, and *Fight Club* is its most radical instance because its awakening and its simulation are the same person. Joel Schumacher's *Falling Down* (1993), whose laid-off defence engineer crosses Los Angeles in a widening spiral of violence, is the cycle's precursor.

The afterlife confirms the pattern. Sam Esmail's *Mr. Robot* (2015–19) rewrote *Fight Club* for networked finance. Its hacker protagonist is accompanied by a double wearing the face of his dead father, and his collective's "5/9" attack wipes out the consumer-debt records of the conglomerate E Corp, achieving digitally what Project Mayhem achieved by demolition; Maxence Cyrin's piano rendition of the Pixies song that closes Fincher's film plays in the ninth episode of the first season, shortly after the revelation that Mr. Robot exists only in the protagonist's head. Yet the series finally grounds its dissociation in childhood trauma, re-pathologizing as individual history what *Fight Club* had made structural. Todd Phillips's *Joker* (2019) takes the opposite path. Its protagonist kills three young financiers on a subway train, and a masked crowd adopts him; recognition, refused by everyone in his life, is granted by the riot. *Joker* is autothymia resolved through the mob, the solution the narrator of *Fight Club* refuses when he shoots Tyler and takes Marla's hand.





07

CHAPTER SEVEN

Toward a Saponific Dialectic

STAGE 07 / DIALECTIC / SPLIT PRODUCT

The saponific dialectic differs from the Hegelian in one decisive respect: its negation yields not a synthesis but a schism, a commodity and a weapon, and every critique that runs the reaction to completion will deliver both.

7.1 Chemism and the Limits of the Triad

In the *Science of Logic*, chemism is the second moment of objectivity, after mechanism and before teleology. The chemical object is in itself the whole concept but is determined by its relation to an other; differentiated objects stand in tension toward one another; their process issues in a neutral product in which their opposed determinations are extinguished; and that product can be split apart again, so that chemism falls back into its starting point. Because the neutral product lacks any immanent drive to further development, chemism must pass over into teleology, the logic of purpose. Hegel's chemism is a dialectic whose products are dead.

Fight Club's dialectic is a chemism in this sense, and the fact explains its refusal of *Aufhebung*. The meeting of fat and lye produces no higher unity carrying both moments forward. It produces two products, neither of which is Spirit: soap, an inert commodity, and glycerol, a potential explosion. Neither contains the purpose that would carry the subject beyond the reaction. The familiar triad of thesis, antithesis, and synthesis must therefore give way, for this text and for the class of narratives it represents, to a schema of substrate, reagent, and split product, in which the negation of the given yields a commodified purity on one side and a weaponized residue on the other. Here lies the formal reason that *Fight Club*'s critique of consumerism produces fascism as its by-product: it cannot cleave the fat without liberating the glycerol. The ideological instability that has divided its critics is stoichiometric.

> ***The ideological instability that has divided its critics is stoichiometric.***

7.2 The Ester Bond: Tyler's Litany as Hydrolysis

A triglyceride consists of three fatty-acid chains joined to a glycerol backbone by ester bonds. The narrator's identity has the same structure: three chains, what he does, what he owns, and how he appears, bound to a core of undischarged thymos, the sweet principle of his fat. Tyler's most famous speech is a sequence of hydrolyses. It denies, one attachment after another, that the self is its job, its bank balance, its car, the contents of its wallet, or its khakis. Each negation cleaves an ester bond.

The fate of the products is the text's tragic insight. The cleaved chains do not vanish; they combine with the cation of Tyler's order and precipitate as hard soap. The identifications the narrator sheds return as the uniform of the movement: black clothing, shaved heads, service jobs, interchangeable bodies, an identity once again purchased, this time with obedience. The core, freed from its esterification to consumer attachments, does not become freedom. It becomes glycerol: sweet, volatile, and, once organized, explosive. Liberation conducted as saponification yields a commodity and a weapon, and by the end the narrator has been rendered.

Tyler's litany cleaves the narrator's fat: the shed identities precipitate as soap and the freed core as glycerol, while Marla, the unsaponifiable fraction, passes through unreacted and, held by the wounded narrator, forms the emulsion of the final shot.

7.3 A Table of Correspondences

The correspondences developed in the preceding chapters are set out below. The table summarizes rather than proves; each row abbreviates an argument made above.

SAPONIFIC TERM	TEXTUAL INSTANCE	PHILOSOPHICAL CORRELATE	MYTHIC OR LITERARY CORRELATE
Fat (triglyceride)	The catalogue-self; IKEA nesting; insomnia	Bataille's accursed share; Marx's dead labour; Baudrillard's system of objects	The meat hidden in the ox's stomach at Mecone; the Crystal Palace
Lye (sodium hydroxide)	Tyler; the kiss-shaped burn	Hegel's tarrying with the negative; Nietzsche's burned-in memory; Jünger's pain	Prometheus's stolen fire; Loki's venom; Kafka's harrow
Ester hydrolysis	The litany of negations	Kierkegaard's defiant self; the Cynic's defaced currency	The key stolen from the mother's pillow
Amphiphile	The narrator–Tyler compound	Hegel's unhappy consciousness; autothymia	Gilgamesh and Enkidu; Pentheus and Dionysus; Wringhim and Gil-Martin
Micelle	Fight club and its rule of silence	Marcuse's repressive desublimation	Acéphale; the mystery cult
Mesophase	Project Mayhem	Jünger's total mobilization; Shigalyovism	Verkhovensky's cell; Conrad's anarchists
Soap (hard, sodium salt)	The space monkey	Theweleit's armoured body; Agamben's bare life	Benedict's novice; the Jesuit corpse
Glycerol, nitrated	The bombs; the erased debt record	Bataille's catastrophic expenditure; Derrida's archiviolithic drive	Ragnarök; the first meridian
Unsaponifiable fraction	Marla Singer	Levinas's face; Winnicott's holding environment	Hesiod's woman, revalued as remainder
Emulsion	The final shot	A metastable colloid in place of *Aufhebung*	The green earth after Ragnarök

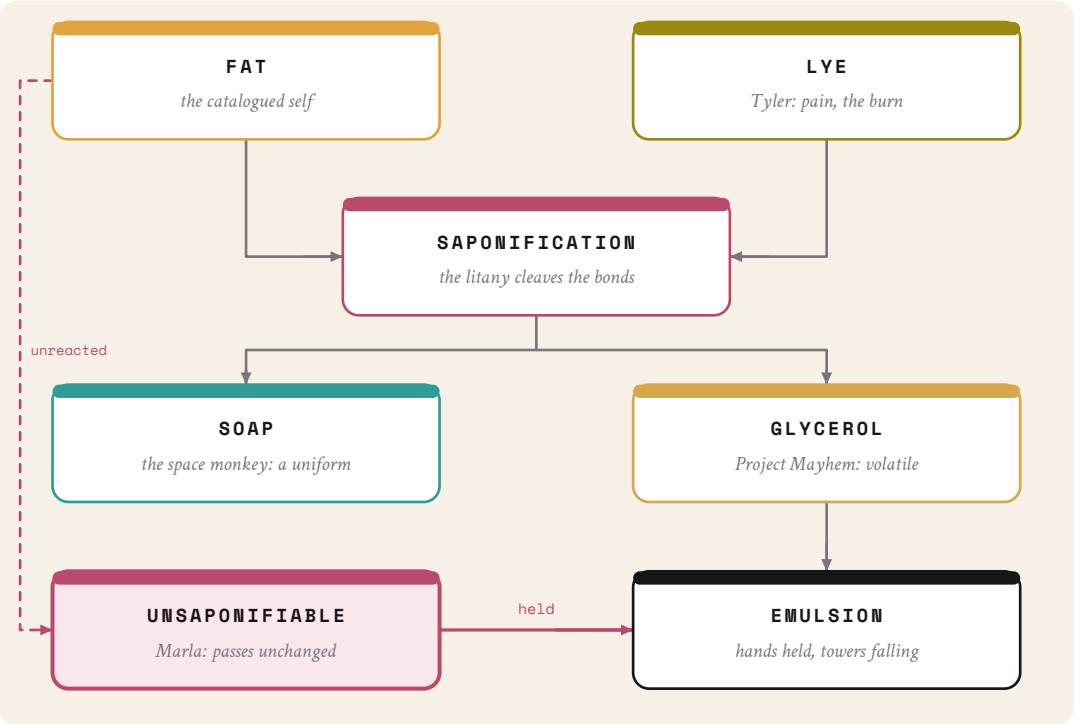


FIG. 10 THE SAPONIFIC DIALECTIC

Substrate, reagent and split product: a commodity and a weapon, while the unsaponifiable passes through and, held, forms the emulsion.

7.4 Autothymia and Autoimmunity

In his dialogue with Giovanna Borradori after 11 September 2001, Derrida described autoimmunity as the process by which a living being, in quasi-suicidal fashion, works to destroy its own protection, immunizing itself against its own immunity; he read the attacks as autoimmune, carried out by al-Qaeda hijackers who had trained in American flight schools and turned American airliners into weapons, and he traced their milieu in part to Washington's Cold War arming of the Afghan resistance to the Soviet Union, a claim about lineage rather than direct sponsorship. Autothymia terminates in autoimmunity. Tyler was produced as a defence, a second self to supply the recognition the narrator could not obtain; by the end the defence has become the gravest threat to its host, and it can be destroyed only by an attack on the body that sustains it. The text stages that turn literally before it stages the shot. When the narrator tries to turn himself in, the detectives prove to be members of Project Mayhem and move to carry out Tyler's standing order that anyone who interferes with the project, Tyler included, is to be castrated; the narrator escapes only by seizing an officer's gun. The threat the movement used against the police commissioner is turned against its own founder, completing a chain that be-

gins with Bob's removed testicles: castration first suffered, then threatened against authority, and finally threatened against the self, which is the autoimmune logic in bodily form.

The narrator's final act is calibrated with clinical precision. He places the gun in his mouth and fires so that the bullet passes through his cheek; the wound is not fatal, and in the film's visual logic the exit wound opens in the back of Tyler's head while the narrator remains standing. The dose kills the double without killing the host: a homeopathic act, the pharmakon at its most exact, a measured quantity of the poison administered to cure the poisoning. Lye, swallowed, is lethal; the narrator takes the caustic into his mouth in a dose he survives. Its cost is inscribed on his face, which now has a second mouth, and it is through this wound that he speaks the text's last line to Marla. Yet the autoimmune process continues without him. Project Mayhem, acephalic at last, completes its work, and the towers fall. The organism has survived its defence; the system has not survived its own.

7.5 Amargi

David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) observed that the first recorded word for freedom, the Sumerian *amargi*, appears in the debt cancellations of Uruinimgina of Lagash in the twenty-fourth century BCE and literally means "return to the mother," because those freed from debt bondage could return to their families. The Babylonian kings' *mīšarum* edicts continued the practice, and Leviticus 25 codified it as the Jubilee: in the fiftieth year *deror*, liberty, cognate with the Akkadian *andurārum*, was to be proclaimed throughout the land, and each man was to return to his possession and to his family. Nietzsche's prophecy of a second innocence, deliverance from the debt owed to one's origin, is the philosophical form of the same dream.

Fight Club is saturated with amargi. Its most explicit form is the erasure of the credit record, which Tyler promises will return everyone to zero; its most intimate is the narrator's first peace, weeping against Bob's maternal chest. Between them lie the nesting instinct with which his consumption is introduced; Tyler's polemic against a generation of men raised by women, which disguises the regression it denies; the pastoral apocalypse of the green earth; and the novel's ending, in which the narrator wakes in an asylum he takes for Heaven, is held, fed, and sedated, and is told by orderlies who belong to Project Mayhem that they look forward to having him back. D. W. Winnicott (1960) named the *holding environment*, the maternal provision within which the infant can exist without having to react to impingement; the novel's asylum is that environment institutionalized, and Freud's oceanic feeling is its affect.

This dissertation therefore proposes that amargi, rather than violence or masculinity, is the true object of the text's desire: release from debt imagined as a return to an origin prior to obligation. The masculinist violence through which the desire is pursued is the form it takes when the maternal origin is simultaneously longed for and repudiated, and the misogyny of Tyler's sermons is the defence against a regressive longing that the text, at its most candid, admits.

Theweleit's soldier male, armouring himself against the flood into which he secretly wishes to dissolve, has the same structure.

The political meaning of amargi follows. The clean slate is the obscene utopia of every debt society: necessary, because debt without release eventually destroys the society it organizes, and forbidden, because release threatens the order of creditors. The novel's asylum and the censored ending of 2022 agree in refusing it; the film grants it in fantasy and pays for the grant with towers. In the decade after the financial crisis, Strike Debt's Rolling Jubilee (2012) attempted amargi with the market's own instruments, buying distressed medical debt for pennies on the dollar and abolishing it, and *Mr. Robot* imagined it as a hack. Each restages one scene: the record of obligation erased, and the debtor sent home.

7.6 The Unsaponifiable: Marla Singer

Every natural fat contains a fraction that does not react with the base: sterols, tocopherols, hydrocarbons, pigments. In animal fats the principal sterol is cholesterol, from which the body synthesizes the steroid hormones, testosterone, oestradiol, and progesterone, that inscribe sexual difference. The fact is chemical, but its bearing on *Fight Club* is exact: the reaction cannot render sexual difference. Bob's body, transformed by steroids and by the hormonal consequences of his cancer, and Marla, the woman the reaction cannot process, both belong to the unsaponifiable.

Marla is the only principal character who joins neither fight club nor Project Mayhem. She smokes in the cancer groups, steals clothes from laundromats to sell, telephones the narrator after taking an overdose of Xanax that she herself calls a cry for help rather than a real attempt, sleeps with Tyler, asks the narrator to examine her breast for a lump, and is repeatedly expelled from the house and from the narrative. She refuses both products of the reaction: she will not be purified, and she does not explode. She remains what Mary Douglas would call dirt, matter out of place, and what the text's misogyny calls a tumour. Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) located the ethical in the face of the Other, which resists every attempt to comprehend it within a totality and, in its exposure, forbids murder. Fincher frames Marla's face in close-up, smeared, exposed, ironic, and it is the one face in the film that no system absorbs.

The feminist critique of *Fight Club*, from Giroux's indictment to the larger argument of Susan Faludi's *Stiffed* (1999), which located the crisis of American men in the betrayal of the promise of useful work rather than in feminization, and to M. J. Clark's reading of the film through Faludi as an exposure of patriarchy's own emasculating economics (2002), is not refuted by this reading. Tyler's misogyny is real, and so is the Promethean structure in which woman arrives as punishment. What the chemical model adds is the location of the point at which that structure fails. The text cannot process Marla, and its only exit from the reaction runs

through her. She is Hesiod's woman revalued: not the punishment that follows the theft of fire, but the remainder the fire could not consume.

The reading must also meet the strongest objection to it. Casting Marla as the ethical remainder risks repeating a familiar move of male conversion narratives, in which a woman exists to redeem a man. The objection holds against any reading that makes her the reward of the narrator's recovery. It does not hold against this one, because the unsaponifiable is defined by resistance rather than function: Marla's refusal of the reaction precedes the narrator's conversion, does not depend on it, and would persist without it. What the objection rightly identifies is the limit of the film's final image, which still frames her as the object of his gesture. The text can locate its exit in her; it cannot yet imagine the scene from her side.

7.7 The Emulsion

The film's final shot places the narrator and Marla at the window of an upper floor as the credit buildings collapse in sequence across the city. He takes her hand and tells her that she met him at a very strange time in his life. The Pixies' "Where Is My Mind?" begins, and a single frame of male genitalia, Tyler's signature as projectionist, is spliced into the image.

An emulsion is a dispersion of one liquid in another with which it does not mix, stabilized at the interface by an amphiphile; it is metastable, kinetically persistent but thermodynamically destined to separate. The narrator, wounded and speaking through the hole in his face, is the amphiphile at the interface between two immiscibles: the catastrophe outside the window, the glycerol's release, and the hand beside him, the unsaponifiable. The image is not a synthesis. Nothing in it sublates catastrophe and intimacy into a higher unity; the two remain distinct, suspended together for the duration of a shot, and the film ends before they separate. The interpretive camps described in the Introduction are attempts to turn this emulsion into a solution, either dissolving the catastrophe in the intimacy and calling the film satire, or dissolving the intimacy in the catastrophe and calling it fascist. Both misrecognize its colloidal nature.

The spliced frame is the residue the ending cannot wash out: Tyler's obscenity incorporated into the medium itself, the film's own unsaponifiable remainder. The film has done to its audience what Tyler did to the audiences of his projection booth, and the closing image is contaminated by the double it has just expelled. Earlier, Tyler's direct address to the camera, during which the image seems to jolt in its sprockets, and his explanation of the cue marks that signal a reel change, had already shown the medium possessed.

The composite text, finally, is organized by three hands. In the novel Tyler first appears on a beach, arranging driftwood logs so that their shadow forms a giant, perfect hand for a single minute: the simulacral hand, an image made of dead wood and light. The burned hand is the inscribed hand of initiation, debt, and the Real. The held hand of the film's final shot is the hand of the Other. Heidegger, in *What Is Called Thinking?* (1951–52), held that only a being who

speaks can have a hand, and that the hand reaches, receives, and gives; Derrida's "Geschlecht II" (1987) examined what that claim excluded. The trajectory of *Fight Club* runs from the shadow to the scar to the touch, and the touch is the recognition autothymia could not produce: recognition received from an independent self-consciousness. Hegel's mutual recognition becomes possible at the end, but only as a gesture among ruins, not as an institution.

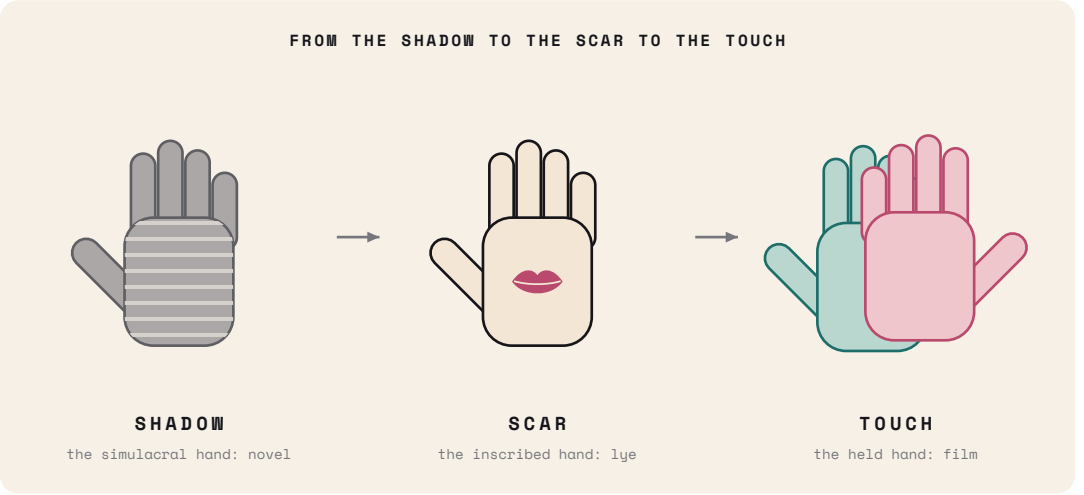


FIG. 11 THREE HANDS

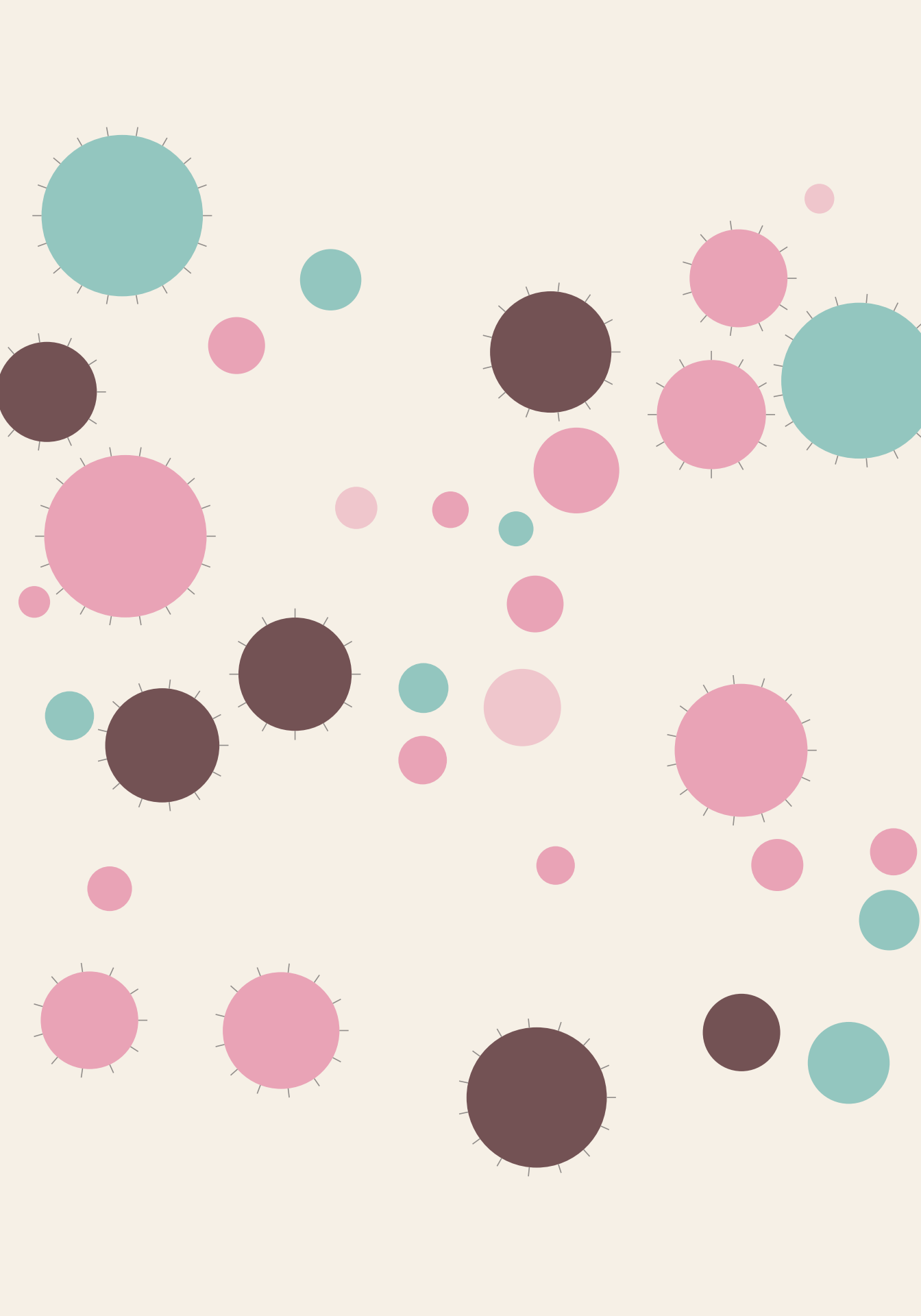
The shadow hand of the novel's beach, the hand inscribed by lye, the hand held in the final shot.

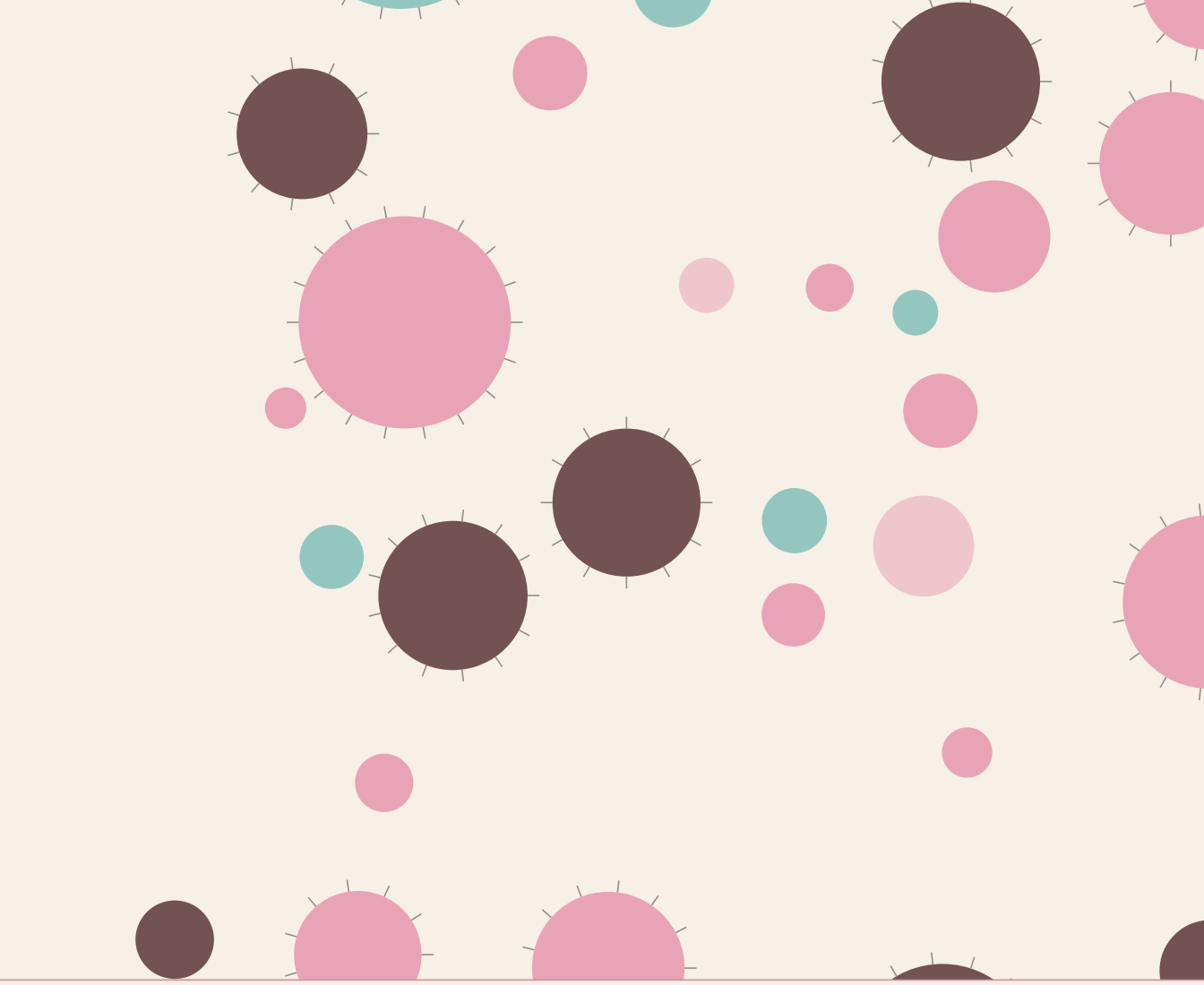
7.8 The Text as Rendering Plant

The reception of *Fight Club* is itself a saponification. The text has been rendered into soap: posters, T-shirts, its rules recited as memes, the aesthetic of the bruised and shirtless man sold back to the audience it describes. Thomas Frank's *The Conquest of Cool* (1997) had shown how the advertising industry of the 1960s absorbed the counterculture's rebellion; Joseph Heath and Andrew Potter's *The Rebel Sell* (2004) argued that countercultural critique is itself a motor of consumption; Naomi Klein's *No Logo* (1999), published the year of the film, traced the brand's colonization of public space and the culture-jamming that answered it. The text has also been rendered into glycerol: the inverted snowflake, the manosphere's adoption of Tyler, the radicalization that takes the narrator's double for his model. The two products of the reception are the two products of the plot.

The critic's task, on this account, is to locate a work's unsaponifiable fraction and to refuse its rendering. *Saponific criticism*, as a general method, asks five questions of any narrative of conversion, radicalization, or self-overcoming. What is the fat, the accumulated identity the narrative proposes to cleave? What is the lye, the negating agent? What are the products: what com-

modity does the liberated self become, and what weapon does its liberated core become? What is unsaponifiable, the remainder the reaction cannot process? And does the ending form a solution or an emulsion? Applied to *American Psycho*, the method finds a fat without lye, and therefore no remainder; to *Joker*, a reaction run entirely to glycerol; to *The Matrix*, a lye supplied from outside and a soap that calls itself the One; to *Mr. Robot*, a reaction reversed into the history of a wound. Applied to *Fight Club*, it finds a text that runs the reaction almost to completion and stops, at the last moment, at a hand.





08

CONCLUSION

Against the Reaction

STAGE 08 / THE REMAINDER

Fight Club is a rendering plant for the late-capitalist male subject, and its wisdom, insofar as it has any, lies not in completing the reaction but in interrupting it.

This dissertation has argued that the composite text's philosophy has the form of saponification. The narrator's catalogued self is a fat, the congealed accursed share of a life organized by commodity, non-place, and actuarial formula (Chapter One). Tyler is the lye, the caustic negativity in which Hegel's tarrying with the negative, Nietzsche's burned-in memory and genealogy of debt, Heidegger's being-toward-death, Kierkegaard's defiant despair, Jünger's second consciousness, counterfeit Zen, and Cynic shamelessness converge (Chapter Two). The two are one amphiphilic molecule, and their relation is autothymia, the struggle for recognition conducted inside a single skull after the end of history, with its dynamics of splitting, inversion, escalation, collectivization, and autoimmunity (Chapter Three). Fight club is a micelle that cleans society of male aggression by concealing it; past a critical concentration it orders itself into Project Mayhem, whose glycerol is spent in a negative potlatch against the archives of value (Chapter Four). Beneath the plot lies the Promethean division of fat at Mecone, together with the wild double of Gilgamesh, the stranger-god of the *Bacchae*, Jacob's wound, the Nobody of the *Odyssey*, and the pharmacy of the *Phaedrus* (Chapter Five). Around it stands a speculative tradition, from Huxley, Zamyatin, and Burgess to Dick and Ballard, that had already imagined a world without a sovereign to rebel against (Chapter Six). And the reaction yields not a synthesis but a schism, a commodity and a weapon, from which only the unsaponifiable escapes (Chapter Seven).

Three concepts carry the argument beyond the text. Autothymia names a deficit of recognition that late capitalism produces structurally rather than individually, and its pertinence has grown since 1999, as the single-serving other has migrated from the airport to the screen and the micelle from the basement to the forum. Amargi names the political unconscious of debt societies, the clean slate they need and forbid, and it shows that the text's masculinist violence is the deformed expression of a regressive longing for release. The unsaponifiable names the ethical remainder: what can be neither purified nor weaponized, and what therefore offers the only exit from a reaction that would otherwise consume its subject entirely.

The method has limits. The chemical model is heuristic, and like every master metaphor it risks rendering its object, cleaving a text into tidy products and discarding whatever does not react. A saponific criticism must accordingly be self-critical in a specific sense: it must ask what in its own reading has been treated as fat and what has been allowed to remain. This dissertation has tried to mark where its correspondences are structural rather than genealogical, and it has preferred to leave Marla's irreducibility unresolved rather than convert her into a symbol. Further work might test the method on other narratives of conversion and radicalization, from *Crime and Punishment* to the contemporary memoir of online awakening, where the same question recurs: whether the liberated self becomes a uniform, a weapon, or a person.

The novel's narrator ends in an asylum he believes is Heaven, awaited by the men who will render him again. The film's narrator ends at a window, wounded, holding the hand of the one person the reaction could not process. Between these endings lies the text's philosophy. If *Fight Club* has a first rule, it is not that one does not talk about fight club. It is that one does not finish the reaction: that the fat be spared, the caustic be taken only in a dose that does not kill, and the remainder be held.

> ***One does not finish the reaction.***



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KEYWORDS

Fight Club | Chuck Palahniuk | David Fincher | Jim Uhls | saponification | saponific criticism | autothymia | amargi | the unsaponifiable | thymos | struggle for recognition | Honneth | end of history | Hegel | Kojève | Fukuyama | Nietzsche | genealogy of debt | second innocence | Kierkegaard | Heidegger | being-toward-death | Jünger | Bataille | expenditure | accursed share | potlatch | Acéphale | Girard | mimetic desire | the double | dissociation | autoimmunity | Derrida | pharmakon | archive | commodity fetishism | reification | simulacra | spectacle | non-places | therapeutic culture | masculinity | misogyny | Theweleit | Cynicism | Zen | Promethean myth | Mecone | Gilgamesh | Iron John | *Bacchae* | Gnosticism | speculative fiction | dystopia | Huxley | Zamyatin | Burgess | Philip K. Dick | J. G. Ballard | Hogg | Dostoevsky | Borges | 1999 cinema | *Mr. Robot* | debt jubilee | material imagination.